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Virginia Board of Education, Work Session (Part 2), Wednesday, October 28, 2026

Date	Wednesday, October 28, 2026
Place	Virginia Board of Education (Virginia Department of Education), Richmond, Virginia
Length	5h 21m (video)

- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=P2m7OZiEvpA
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-11-05. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:02:08] Closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act, section 2.2-3712 of the Code of Virginia requires that the board certify that to the best of each member's knowledge, only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter, and only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened, were heard, discussed, or considered.

[00:02:36] Any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote, indicating the substance of the departure that in his or her judgment has taken place. The statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes. We'll do a roll call.

[00:02:51] Mr. Robinson? Aye. Dr. Bridges? Aye. Dr. Wilson? Aye. Dr. Maxwell? Aye. Mrs. Kilgore? Aye. And chair votes aye. Thank you. Our next item of business is to vote on a series of licensure matters that have been under review by the Board of Education during executive session.

[00:03:18] In our first case, 2026-34, the chair will entertain a motion to issue the license. So moved. Is there a second? Second. Okay, we'll do a roll call.

[00:03:34] Mr. Robinson? Aye. Dr. Bridges? Aye. Dr. Wilson? Aye. Dr. Maxwell, Mrs. Kilgore. Aye. And Chair votes aye. In case 2026-33, the Chair will entertain a motion to suspend the license of Hannah

Kathleen Fetterman until January 26, 2027.

[00:04:03] So moved. Is there a second? Is there a second? Second. Okay. Thank you. Mr. Robinson. Aye. Dr. Bridges? Aye. Dr. Wilson? Aye. Dr. Maxwell? Mrs. Kilgore? And Chair votes aye. Thank you. That concludes our licensure hearings. We will now take a brief break. What time is it? We're going to reconvene at 11 o'clock. Take a brief break. Thank you.

[00:04:36] We are incredibly grateful to reconvene back in our working session with comments from our secretary.

[00:16:18] Before he comes to the podium, I'm going to turn it over to Superintendent Conway. Wonderful. Thank you all, and good morning. I am pleased to introduce your Secretary of Education, Dr. Jeffrey Smith. You may know this, you may not.

[00:16:35] He always does love it when I talk about how many years of service he has in Virginia public schools, but he began as an educator and has worked at every level of our system with 30 plus, and we'll leave it at that, years committed to Virginia's students.

[00:16:55] He's been a teacher, an assistant principal, a principal, worked in central office, and was superintendent of West Point and of Hampton City, where he demonstrated his absolute steadfast commitment to academic excellence as he helped Hampton City schools, along with a broad array of educators, leaders, and community stakeholders, to achieve, at the time, historic highs.

[00:17:25] in terms of accreditation performance and graduation rates he'll give you the specifics but they really showed how he brought help bring a community together to deliver results for uh students he is married to a lifelong educator uh raised two children who attended our public schools um and uh you know has been a partner in crime with me since we were both announced in january showing deep respect for the role that the Department of Education can play in addition to other parts of his portfolio, which include our higher ed partners,

[00:18:04] our community college partners, and our museum partners. He, even with all of his incredible experience and deep, deep relationships, no matter where he goes, I'm sure there'll be a story about someone he knows here on this board or in this building, but he has shown me and the senior leadership team the department of education extraordinary mutual respect is always open to our feedback and as we traveled the state on the commonwealth listening tour as well as our back to school tour i've always felt like he's a partner who believes in excellence for every student every day with that

[00:18:44] i'm so pleased to call dr smith to the podium thank you uh madam state superintendent let me just again in terms of my remarks by acknowledging the fact to Madam Chair of the Board and also to the Vice Chair and certainly to each member of the Board of Education. It's my absolute delight to join you this morning and to share some brief remarks as it relates to really focusing on some of the priorities that have been established. Certainly it's a pleasure for me to serve in the

[00:19:23] Commonwealth, again, having been appointed by our governor to serve as the Secretary of Education. And so what a delight it is for me to work alongside and in support of the great work of our state superintendent as she continues to focus on what we know teaching and learning.

[00:19:42] Our core business is that of teaching and learning and how do we prepare students for success in whatever those chapters might be once they walk across the stage. Quite frankly, we all understand that

a high school diploma is important, but equal to that is to make certain that young people have, that students have, as a part of their portfolio, certifications, stackable credentials that they can take with them as they walk across the stage and they have a high school diploma.

[00:20:18] And so it is about preparing them for the three E's, whether that's going to be employment or it's going to be enrollment or it's going to be enlistment. And so how do we get young people as close as we possibly can to their dreams and their aspirations?

[00:20:37] And so today you will hear me talk a little bit about that. I wanna say to you as members of the State Board of Education along with the State Superintendent, thank you for your exceptional leadership. We have a lot of work ahead of us, and thank you for the contributions that you have already made in support of public education and the students and the families that we serve across the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:21:07] Our focus is simply in the work to make certain that we operate from a place of understanding and knowing that we are building from places of strength. That is the approach for the work that we're building from places of strength.

[00:21:24] And quite frankly, from that standpoint, to know and to embrace that our schools and the school systems and the leadership that we interact with every day, they're working hard on behalf of students and families.

[00:21:42] And I have said, quite frankly, as a superintendent of 15 years and 32 years and nine months before I thought I had retired, right? That I witnessed and experienced the great work that's going on and that we must stay on the path of continuous improvement and focusing on continuous improvement.

[00:22:05] But the fact of the matter is that our schools and our systems, they're not broken. It's how do we build from those places of strength and how do we help them to embrace and to have the resources, but also the processes and systems in place to really focus on continuous improvement, focusing on continuous improvement along the way.

[00:22:31] And so with that, it's my pleasure to really be here and to thank you for your leadership, some of the decisions and the hard work that you have already engaged in around processes and systems thinking, because at the end of the day, want to make certain that we leave in place not just activities and initiatives but to leave in place processes and systems that will outlive our leadership whether it's on the board of education whether it's the state superintendent or whether it's the secretary of education that is the charge

[00:23:09] from our governor to make certain that we anchor this work and that we really focus on the quality of our system, and that we deliver through processes, and that we deliver through well-defined systems that will outlast our leadership, and that will serve Virginians and certainly our young people and families for future years to come. So with that in mind, I think we'll move to the next slide. Let me just begin by saying that first, let's talk about our governor and

[00:23:47] the governor's mission. And simply, and yet it's complex, but it is one that will lead and guide the work that we are engaged in. That's to build a durable future with opportunity for all Virginians. At the end of the day, to ensure that we're addressing the needs of all virginians and and this is accomplished uh really through ensuring affordable health care and utilities and housing and more but also ensuring strong schools uh safe and healthy communities

[00:24:20] and good jobs in every corner of virginia and making government work for virginians and so strong public schools we know um without question that they are central to really achieving the mission that is set forth by the governor and her administration it's essential not only to the success of our students but also really to the long-term economic vitality

[00:24:55] and and the well-being of our communities and so within the education department you will note that our charge is really to ensure strong schools, that we contribute to the work there, and that we also contribute to safe and healthy communities, and that we prepare young people for success in post-secondary education and the workforce. That's the foundation as to how we connect with the mission set forth by the governor and at the end of the day to have clarity around

[00:25:34] the mission set forth by the governor and how we will engage in that particular mission that we have in in front of in front of us so that young people can can choose and they can decide um in terms of the paths that they're going to take and so central to to the mission absolutely strong schools and so that's why the partnership with state superintendent and with the board of education it's so important that we work together to move that needle around student achievement and success

[00:26:10] with all that we will engage in and many things that will capture our attention nothing is more important than the core business of teaching and learning and how we set young people up for success and the fact of the matter that there are no shortcuts to excellence at the end of the day it is hard and deliberate and focused work there are no shortcuts to excellence so let's with that let's lean into uh the priorities and let's begin so you have eight in front of you uh the eight uh

[00:26:44] priorities in in in front of you and of course when we think of the work that we're engaged in uh in working with the virginia department of education um there are other aspects to the work that we'll lean in and so forth and i also want to say that um uh when we think of the virginia department of education our state superintendent i know with the strategic planning this is not an override of the strategic plan this is in collaboration with and in support of the strategic plan and how can we support the work and work alongside the Virginia Department of

[00:27:22] Education. So let's think of it in terms of early childhood care and education. We'll talk a little bit more about that in terms of a priority, teaching and learning, college and career readiness, assessment and accountability, and then teacher recruitment and retention, wraparound supports, and then certainly the world of AI and technology usage. I will say that from my previous years as a superintendent, I used to say that technology, it is a resource

[00:27:54] and it should not be a driver. It is a 21st century resource, not a driver in terms of the delivery of high quality instruction and then funding formula reform and the work that we will be engaged in there. So at the end of the day, the focus here, it is about how we strengthen the instruction and how we improve the processes and the systems that are in front of us around whether it's our assessment and accountability system, whether it's the

[00:28:30] teaching and learning and we can provide you know all of the resources um but at the end of the day when we have the resources that are in place whether or not we have the systems uh if we provide resources and initiatives let's think about the professional development and the and the requirement of the professional development and whether or not we have a two or three year professional development plan that's aligned with any initiative or area that we're focusing on so that the school divisions can lean

and understand with clarity but not only understand with clarity can move forth and implement with fidelity and that's that will be important so you have the

[00:29:09] eight there so let's talk a little bit about early childhood uh care and and education most recently uh the state superintendent and i had the pleasure of uh being in newport news uh with the um early child care education commission and working alongside them and so one of the priorities is just ensuring that children enter kindergarten ready to learn and that's important it's foundational to everything else to make certain that they are ready to learn and we want that

[00:29:43] every virginia family that they would have access to affordable but not only affordable high quality early childhood options across the commonwealth of virginia and so in essence really it means both expanding access and strengthening the quality of early learning experiences with continued focus on kindergarten readiness and so we recognize and we offer an acknowledgement this morning about the critical role of the virginia department of education

[00:30:18] and certainly with our state superintendent how she has leaned in uh and that we are on the national leading edge uh in terms of the work here so thank you and more to come in that regard uh as we as we partner together the next is that of teaching and learning uh and and we all know and and can agree i think that high quality instruction uh it is essential and uh to the work that we are engaged in and so we call it tier one support it's about the heart of improving

[00:30:54] student outcomes and so if we think of a pyramid with three layers to it tier one tier two tier three what is most important to make certain that at tier one we we have uh the curriculum high quality um instructional materials our state superintendent has taught me how to say that quite well high quality instructional materials high quality instructional materials but that they're embedded in the curriculum and that teachers are delivering with fidelity because we've provided the resources with professional development and to make certain that we have

[00:31:30] the appropriate lesson design and delivery in tier one that we have the professional development in tier one all around making certain that we are as strong as we possibly can in the area of tier one with our teaching and learning and so uh it's the center core of the work thank you uh for your leadership and certainly the general assembly around the virginal the virginia literacy act and our ongoing work in terms of strengthening uh the science of reading and we know that the science of reading at the end of the day with the virginia literacy act that the professional

[00:32:06] development around phonemic awareness and phonics and fluency and vocabulary and comprehension, that it is essential and it's important that we really focus on that science of reading and the professional development opportunities and coaching around the science of reading with our teachers, but also in the area of mathematics and the importance of mathematics and the science teaching mathematics as well so what happens then when students don't master what we expect them to know understand and be able to do from a tier one what

[00:32:44] are the interventions that we have at a tier two and tier three level in reading and in mathematics important to the journey of teaching and learning to make certain that teachers have not just what they need and our educators in that tier one, but we have opportunities in place for tier two interventions and tier three interventions

[00:33:12] as well. And a tier two, maybe high dosage tutoring, real time in place, addressing what some of the needs might be of some of the learners who may be experiencing difficulty, whether it's in literacy or it's in mathematics with a tier one, that we're very intentional about our tier two, tier three interventions for students.

[00:33:40] And so the teaching and learning, it's important. And so the work that we're engaged in, it is important. And so you have before you the teaching and learning priority there. And then college and career readiness.

[00:33:59] How do we then expand dual enrollment opportunities and strengthen career pathways to ensure that students, when they leave, they graduate from high school prepared for, whether it's the enrollment, whether it's the enlistment, or whether it's employment.

[00:34:19] It's college, career, and careers, and beyond. And to also build out our focus here, a framework of career readiness, a framework so that school divisions, it would be flexible enough for school divisions to build their own capacity within local areas to focus on here are career options for you as you think about the work that you're engaged in and the teaching and the learning, to think about career pathways in the workforce

[00:34:58] because all of us want to ensure that young people, when they graduate, that they have a plan and that that plan is going to set them up for success. so this is a priority. The other is assessment and accountability. You know the story of assessment and accountability. In your work, you have been intimately involved in how we might improve our assessment and accountability system to really promote the high expectations, provide meaningful

[00:35:32] support, and drive growth in student outcomes. And so thank you for your leadership there. we have indeed a responsibility there to say that we're measuring what should be measured around the teaching and learning, that we're identifying some of the challenges so that teachers can intervene as early as possible to address some of the challenges that young people might be experiencing along the way. And so we believe deeply in maintaining high expectations

[00:36:07] for every Virginia student, and that commitment is not going to change. At the same time, we know that a strong accountability system must do more than identify where schools currently stand. They must provide, and we believe that it must provide, a very clear and actionable plan of action in terms of information that teachers can use, that superintendents can use to design how they can intervene. And so we recognize the implementation

[00:36:44] of the school performance and support framework. And we also know that there are opportunities to improve, that there are some technical aspects that must be addressed. While the system in its design is there, how can we make certain that it is as strong as it should be, and that school divisions can use what they have and what they're receiving and that they have confidence. And so thank you to the state superintendent. Thank you to the state superintendent's team in getting

[00:37:24] the results out to school divisions most recently on time and with accuracy. Thank you very much for that. And so this is foundation to the work because our educators, our teachers, our superintendents rely heavily on the information that they receive so that they can make decisions regarding the teaching and learning and how best to move forward in local school divisions. And so it should drive a plan of action. And so we will continue

[00:38:01] to work alongside you in this regard. Recruitment and retention. We can have all of the best you know uh and i'm going to lean in uh to uh one of your colleagues on on on the board uh dr wilson we we know uh and and others that we can have all of the right components in place in terms of resources uh interventions but if we can't attract and retain best of the best in terms

[00:38:36] of educators in the classroom it is difficult to move the student achievement needle forward so here with recruitment and retention, you will see that it is really designed in terms of a priority.

[00:38:51] We want to attract and retain more effective educators by strengthening recruitment pipelines, improving compensation, and expanding opportunities for educator preparation, how they prepare themselves in terms of professional development and so forth. All of that is essential because teachers often lean in when the compensation is in place they then will say what are the resources that i have in my school division that i can use uh in preparation for uh a monday a

[00:39:27] tuesday a wednesday a thursday to do to really deliver high quality uh instruction and so recruitment and retention uh it is a priority for the administration and how can we best lean in and support the work in this defined area. So, we look forward to partnering with you in all ways that are appropriate to support the recruitment and the retention of high-quality

[00:39:59] educators. AI and technology, wraparound. Thank you. I think she advanced two slides for me. And so, to ensure that we improve our wraparound services across the Commonwealth of Virginia, that is a priority as well to meet the unique physical mental and behavioral health needs of students it's an area that we know that we can have the teaching and learning on one side of that pyramid where we have tier one tier two tier three uh but but we also have the climate and the

[00:40:36] culture on the other side and what are the resources that we have in place wraparounds supports for uh students but but but also for adults um as they engage in the important work of teaching and learning uh and so this is an area of of priority we know that for students they don't care how much we know until they know how much we really care uh and so their well-being and whether we have uh the resources this is an absolute priority for the governor when i met with

[00:41:14] the governor and we reviewed and discussed priorities, this particular topic emerged to say, "Yes, the teaching and the learning, the science, the math, the professional development, but we also must ensure that the wraparound supports are in place for students and for the adults as well."

[00:41:35] And then that leads us to the AI and technology use to really equip Virginia educators with the tools that they need and the training and the guidance to harness the emerging technologies safely and ethically and in a responsible way and to peel those particular layers back as we work in collaboration and in support of the work of the Virginia Department of Education as well. And then we have spent a lot of time over the years talking about the funding formula

[00:42:15] and and the importance of the funding formula and that it's student driven and with a focus on students and the resources that they need and so i'm happy to report that we have a a task force and with the task force an advisory on the technical side but we also have a stakeholder funding formula advisory group. I'm delighted to say that this week we had the joint subcommittee

[00:42:53] that really approved the RFP that was developed by the state superintendent and members of the Virginia Department of Education around the funding formula to really now secure a consultant who will focus on um the model and provide some recommendations going forward but this is essential uh as

as we go as we go forward and how we might partner with you uh in this regard so it is a priority for uh the governor's administration so here's some examples of early progress and i'll quickly go through these slides and then pause and answer any questions that that you might have

[00:43:32] uh and so uh it was a pleasure to uh travel with uh our state superintendent across the commonwealth of virginia eight um regions um i thought that you know i could really keep the pace and uh and realize that after 32 years and nine months um that after eight regions uh you you need a moment to take a break and regroup and so we were able to visit all eight regions and and what we heard we were able to celebrate the great work that's going on but they also identified for us

[00:44:11] opportunities leaned in and said this is where you can help us um in terms of resources processes systems thinking uh this is how you can support us and then slow down in terms of initiatives to make certain that we we're not living off of initiatives that we're implementing and we're implementing things well and we are running um models that we're modeling before we push

[00:44:49] initiatives out to know what the impact is going to be and evidence-based strategies uh around around the work so the listening uh tour was a great opportunity for us but also uh the strong schools tour this fall where uh the opening of school uh to see our educators to teachers our support staff everyone engaged in the work we had an opportunity we spent time visiting classrooms um and asking teachers about the opening of school and so um so this is an

[00:45:23] area of accomplishment force. The next area, within the education secretary, 200 bills that we provided, that we reviewed, and 100 with technical support. And I think that I will attribute to getting an eye, a stye on my eye from the fatigue of reading and the work that we were engaged there.

[00:45:52] Thank you to the Virginia Department of Education, the state superintendent, for your technical support and your review in helping to identify areas that we could really strengthen some of the bills that were put forth. The next area of accomplishment, you know, historic budget investments in education, including $2 million in new education funding. That is significant. And as I said earlier, funding is important.

[00:46:27] But we all know that the resources, they are important, but equal to that. We must make certain that we have the processes and the systems in place around the delivery of those resources.

[00:46:46] What are the processes? What are the systems that we have in place for the delivery to support, to have a system in place that will outlast all of us in terms of our leadership? what we might have in tier one, tier two, tier three. Students, we expect you to master the following, to know, understand, and to be able to do, and then what will happen when you don't master what we expect you to know, understand, and be able to do in terms of outcomes. And so

[00:47:21] the resources, they're important, the funding, absolutely. But included as a part of that, the investment of the 4% raises for teachers and school support staff. We'll go to the next slide. And then you're familiar with the release of the request for proposal to modernize and deliver a high-quality K-12 assessment system that really uses more interactive questions designed to evaluate the critical thinking skills that will give us more information and feedback in a timely manner

[00:47:56] And as we work with our teachers and our families in the regard of assessments to see if students really have mastered what we expect them to know, understand, and be able to do. And then how do we frame those interventions? And so thank you for the action in this regard.

[00:48:16] And I already mentioned the K-12 funding formula task force and the representation of stakeholders throughout the Commonwealth of Virginia, and we look forward to working alongside the stakeholders as we examine the K-12 funding formula and the work that will be involved there.

[00:48:34] And we're now, we're currently working closely with the Virginia Department of Education around the proposed budget and legislative items for the 2027 year and the legislative session that is in front of us.

[00:48:54] And so we have our sleeves rolled up and we're engaged in thoughtful conversations as to those budget aspects that we've proposed for consideration. And also some some legislative considerations that we've asked the governor's team to weigh in and to provide us with some guidance.

[00:49:16] And so we will await for further guidance in this area. In closing, just thank you for your leadership. It's my pleasure to be back in the game again of teaching and learning.

[00:49:35] As a state superintendent will attest, it is what I am passionate about. I believe that all of our young people can achieve. I truly believe that all of our young people are deserving of opportunities to achieve.

[00:49:55] And we firmly believe, in collaboration with the governor, that we have a responsibility to provide the appropriate resources for all of our students to achieve. I'm a product of the public school system.

[00:50:14] I believe in public education. Both of our children traveled through and had great experience and now careers of their own in terms of the public education system. Our governor believes in the public education system, the power of public education, and the fact that our young people can, they deserve, and we have a responsibility.

[00:50:41] Thank you for your leadership. I look forward to working with each of you on behalf of the governor's office. is this is only the beginning. We are going to move the academic achievement needle forward. It is a priority.

[00:50:57] We're going to move that achievement needle forward and make certain that at the end of the day that young people can decide where they want to go and what they want to do. Thank you.

[00:51:15] Happy to answer any questions that you might have. - Okay, now you're on the hot seat. Thank you so much. know i i will start and then we'll see if board members have some questions um first i just want to thank you for taking the time um today but also in your your world tour of virginia um just listening getting feedback and there's a couple things that you said that really resonate with me and i think of the work we do with this board is um leaving a quality system that we improve for future years coming um and so many of the things that you said sound so simple the way you just

[00:51:52] talk sounds so simple but it is hard work um and it's going to take us time but i think the partnership with our families our parents the stakeholders i think that we um the future is bright for our virginia scholars um and with academic achievement at the forefront you know i I think it's a harder or maybe easier question around is that, what are we gonna stop doing?

[00:52:21] You've mentioned a lot of around processes and systems and resources. Can you just share just your reflection on what you heard around like, please stop doing this because it's so clear we need to do this. Does that make sense?

[00:52:37] - No, absolutely. And thanks for asking that question. And I think what we heard very much so in terms of what we need to stop, and that is we heard about the initiative fatigue in terms of too many initiatives at one time.

[00:52:53] Let's be thoughtful and deliberate as it relates to specific initiatives and to make certain that they are focused, that those initiatives, that they're designed around the core business of teaching and learning, student achievement, and success.

[00:53:13] And so what we heard was basically, look, let's make certain we're not going to be good and great everything, but we must make certain that we're good and great as it relates to our core business.

[00:53:31] And so I think with the state superintendent and certainly her leadership, the concept, there are some things that we will need to do around the accountability system and adjustments there and so forth. But to be very thoughtful as we move forward and to say, is this really necessary?

[00:53:50] And to ask ourselves, is this really necessary? Or if it is, let's look and decide from an evidence based strategy standpoint, the value added. And if we have initiatives in place and we know we can't determine that it's value added, that's a true signal that we should stop perhaps doing it.

[00:54:18] if it's not value added we don't have the evidence that it's adding any value it is about that stop start and sustain what should we to your point stop and i think that's the assessment of are some of those initiatives and i think the work that we're engaged in that you are engaged in as a board and the state superintendent and her approach around the strategic plan and the leaning in it's going to lead us down that path uh what should we stop what do we need to start and what do we need

[00:54:54] to sustain and that is the process and so um i think just the fact uh let's monitor closely what we're asking school divisions to do and the leaders in school divisions and when we know that it is necessary, let's give them the why behind it, the why, why this is important, what we anticipate the value at it will be. And this is how we're going to monitor the data that we're going to collect as a part of that rollout. And then, oh, by the way, the professional development that is designed

[00:55:32] to help you implement that with fidelity. So I've answered that probably down four different lanes, but I think it's all important in terms of what we need to stop. I think that's going to, you know, I used to say you can go to a coffee shop and they may serve a lot of other items on the menu, right? But their core business, it's the best coffee, right? And sometimes they can take their eye or eyes off of the core business and lose some of the market because

[00:56:12] they're trying to be good and great at too many things. So to your point, I hope that's helpful. Secretary Smith, thank you so much for spending time with us this morning. I just want to really double click on the wraparound supports piece because, and you know, if I had to prioritize, I would actually put that one first because we know when kids and families get the supports they need, then they are ready to learn. And so I just appreciate of all these priorities, which of course are of critical importance, making sure that our young people are not only taken care of from a

[00:56:50] mental, physical, behavioral perspective, but that they can show up ready to learn and acknowledging the importance of well-being. Because we know even as adults, we can't show up as our best selves at work when we have other things going on. So I just really wanted to highlight and you see all the national data around anxiety rates, stress rates, all the things that our young people are dealing with. And so to be able to say that the governor is prioritizing the well-being of our young people, as well as

these other strategies that are, of course, of core importance, I just wanted to acknowledge that. No, thank you. We appreciate it. And just a follow-up,

[00:57:30] just a comment on that topic. I mean, you said it and you said it well, they can show up and give their best if they aren't in a good place, their mental, behavioral.

[00:57:46] I will say that the Education Secretariat and the Health and Human Resources Secretariat with Secretariat de Figueroa, we're going to be working, we're going to work together to really design a framework in collaboration with the Virginia Department of Education as to how that might look across the Commonwealth of Virginia and a design that school did can lean in and use as a point of reference as they develop their areas within wraparound support.

[00:58:21] Thank you. Thank you so much, Mr. Secretary. I also had circled that wraparound services that my colleague was so interested in.

[00:58:36] You all have probably seen, but last week, the Brookings Brown Center issued their snapshot of American schools and trends. And I just want to highlight two things, which I think amplify what my colleagues said. International tests show that U.S. 15-year-olds compare favorably with peer countries in reading and science.

[00:58:54] We're still struggling in math. We need to work on that. But also in international comparisons, U.S. students are negative outliers in two things, self-reported well-being and time spent on screens. And so to have that as a priority, if she's double-clicking, I guess I'm triple-clicking on that, and thank you very much. The other two things that I circled were professional growth because we've seen the needle move on recruitment in Virginia, and now that retention piece, paying attention to that and really looking at why teachers stay, and I know I'm biased because

[00:59:34] I work with a lot of them, but school leaders play a huge role in why teachers stay, even with compensation on the table. School leaders can make that influence. And also the issue of self-efficacy that we don't talk about very much at all, that if teachers feel empowered, if they feel like they've got that capacity.

[00:59:53] So that professional development piece, I don't see that very much. And I'm so glad that y'all are amplifying that and putting some focus where that serves to be. And I do have one question and that's related to the funding priority. And this is kind of a technical question, but I just want to make sure I'm clear I'm aware of the joint subcommittee's work. I'm aware of the RFP for the study.

[01:00:15] What is the role of the task force and the advisory group you talked about, and sort of how will all of those things work together on this issue? Absolutely. Thank you. So on the technical side with the advisory committee, the goal and the objective it is to really think through at the school division level how the current formula is working, not to really re-litigate that, but to really say, are things working? And then from a technical standpoint, here's some of the challenges that we have experienced. So we have current and former CFOs and superintendents who are serving on the Technical Advisory Committee, and so they will

[01:00:54] lean in in that regard. And so we've charged them to say, give us your technical expertise as you have worked with the LCI, some of the challenges, what are some of the opportunities within that context as well. Then the second piece, stakeholders, on the side of stakeholders to say, talk a little bit about the

impact of the current funding on students and communities. And the information that we will gather there will certainly will fold into once we hire or once

[01:01:32] um we identify in terms of the rfp process a consultant we can then fold some of the information and the feedback that we have received into the consultant in terms of the process that they will be involved in so it really is trying to do some of that work on the front end but not to get into the modeling because the consultant will spend time around the modeling and but this is really gathering information and support so one on the technical side to say talk to us about your

[01:02:07] specific experiences southwest northern virginia tidewater and to lean in uh based upon uh your front pew experience i'll use that frontline experience right uh and uh being on the front line and then the stakeholders in terms of actually from a community perspective uh in leaning in on that thank you that's great and and maybe that can be bridged into some work on the back end too you know there's some really interesting work being done about it's in

[01:02:41] the realm of decision science and some of the folks who work on how those decisions get made because let's be honest there's a reason this thing is 52 years old and that's because everyone sees this one pie and any shift as a threat to a piece of pie I'm privy to and so some of those really contentious decision-making public processes are being rethought from a decision science perspective and so maybe there's a way to do it because I just hate to think about another study and no action and I know y'all don't want that either absolutely I'm looking forward to

[01:03:20] continued work in that realm absolutely thank you thank you first of all thank you again for being here and also um being out in all eight regions and for the uh listening tour then taking a break but then the back to school is just seeing the work a little bit in action it's just so clear how uh the superintendent's office and yours is is truly not just on listening tour but truly listening um and um and using the trust built through that to uh really help us think about

[01:03:55] how we can collectively raise the bar for our students like and um so i'd love also to see you out there last week uh advocating for expanding early learning uh hearing of you uh thinking about this funding formula and what's possible there all of that uh probably requires immense investment at a time that dollar is more stretched as we're also trying to figure out what to do about SNAP being lost and everything like that. And I'm a big believer in advocate for more

[01:04:29] investment where we can see that return. And I'm just curious as you think about these bold priorities that you've laid out, how will you know three, four, whatever time horizon you want put out there years from now, particularly if we can cultivate the stakeholder buy-in we need to to invest and go bold, how will we know if we're successful? How are we starting to think about measurement? Yeah, and so measurement is really going to come by the way of student achievement

[01:05:05] and success. We know the current data that we have around student achievement and success, whether it might be attendance in school, whether we're looking and examining the reading achievement scores, math achievement scores. So I think at the end of the day, at the very highest level, we're focusing on student achievement. And I think those are indicators of success we have to identify and say we have been successful when the following occurs.

[01:05:38] and i think the evidence-based strategies along with the work will lead us to say what should we identify as those indicators of success to your point on the front end ultimately we're going to see it

through student achievement and success and and i think we have to measure it through student achievement and and and success whatever investments we make the professional development if it's in the reading if it is in the math attendance school divisions receiving additional funding what are the outcomes and whether or not we're seeing it in terms of the overall student

[01:06:17] effect i love i love that answer um and to focus on student success ultimately and i i would encourage just a couple things as you think about those those things number one i think it's about 10 to 11 of our divisions across the country now are above where they were pre-pandemic um you know how are we going to ensure we as a state are as well as uh the percentage of divisions here and And then also just with the readiness to learn, I'd love the first priority on how we know if we have K readiness.

[01:06:51] And I'm excited for us to go bold there. But building on that, we had, as a state, hardly any growth from the 2022 to 2024 NAEP. And I think because of the boldness that you and the superintendents teams are doing, I don't know why we couldn't be a top state in the country for growth, particularly in fourth grade NAEP over the next, you know, by 2030. So just want to encourage us to go bold in our goals to help cultivate the resources, the support and accountability to get

[01:07:24] absolutely. Secretary Smith, thank you. Always good to hear your vision and the work that you are doing and leading. So thank you. Two observations. Mr. Robinson's question about that he just raised was one that was on my mind.

[01:07:48] So I'll skip that and go to just an acknowledgement about processing systems that outlive. So we are at a point in time. And so it's really encouraging for me to hear this conversation about how do we ensure that while we are making progress toward teaching and learning that metric, you know, kind of that main thing, that core business, how do we continue that progress while also setting into place processes and systems that outlive any one person, whatever, right?

[01:08:20] And so that commitment and the work that we're gonna hear about in terms of the strategic plan of the department aligning then ultimately to the work that we as a board do. So that through line in terms of a system is really important, right?

[01:08:37] So we are modeling, I hope what we will do is model what we are or demonstrate what we say we are going to do this next little bit of work that then sets the ground the foundation for them moving forward beyond 27 28 29 35 whatever the year happens to be so um i'm encouraged to hear it um and to think about what is possible for every child as we continue to make sure that our focus on our core

[01:09:07] business remains front and center so thank you final word uh i never get the final word with dr smith for the record she knows that i'm always going to come back with one more word after she yeah i know how that operates now i did i wanted to just uh uh thank dr smith and and and and dr wilson just express what i was i am going to express later in terms of the connections between what you have just heard um uh and what we uh chief coy and our new director will be presenting

[01:09:46] this afternoon about the strategic plan i did also want to recognize and appreciate our deputy secretary uh edwards um who has joined the secretariat and has uh playing a key role overseeing the early childhood and k-12 work and has immediately jumped in and being willing to drive with us travel with us uh handle um all of the various things uh that come our way um but i think both dr smith and i remain committed to uh thinking about what it is

[01:10:20] that matters most and how do we make year-over-year progress towards that taking very seriously our role as stewards who sit in this in these seats for a period of time but ultimately you know need to be thinking about what outlasts and are also you know keeping eyes and ears open to sort of what the moment requires and there is always that balance you know in addition to the kind of the start stop and sustain and then sort of what comes you know at you out of out of left field and how are you responsive because those are real kids real educators real communities and that's always

[01:10:55] a balancing act and i just know i'm incredibly appreciative of dr smith as a mentor and somebody who's just done this in so many places and can bring that combination of the big picture but also continuing to stay responsive to what's happening every day thank you so much thank you state superintendent and to the members of the board thank you for your leadership we really look forward to it and i was going to acknowledge dr edwards so thank you for doing so and we look forward to uh i really look forward along with the governor to the journey that is ahead uh for

[01:11:27] each of us and to your point um there is no reason why um we're not in a place of leading the nation that should be our north star through our students uh and the families that we serve and their success so thank you so very much all the best to you thank you well done all right with that final challenge this board needs to have lunch so we will break um uh for till 12 45 to um convene for

[01:12:06] lunch and then we'll follow up with our work session so breaking for lunch thank you officially

[02:03:40] come back to our work session and up next is item b the presentation on back to school tour with that wonderful thank you president ashton um as secretary smith noted we had the opportunity to do a strong schools back to school tour over the course of the late summer and early fall we wanted to get back out and see instruction in action i think we had we had this incredible set of opportunities with the commonwealth listening tour and wanted to make sure that we

[02:04:20] went to areas of of the state that we had uh not necessarily seen before and as chief coy will talk about also prioritizes seeing some of our schools furthest from opportunity uh out as a means to better understand what were some of the strengths to note the secretary's emphasis on kind of being strengths-based in our approach and some of the challenges faced by students, educators, and communities at some of our federally identified schools. So with that, I'll turn it to Chief Coy to walk us through the presentation. Wonderful. Well, thank you, Superintendent Conway,

[02:04:56] and good afternoon, members of the board. It's a pleasure to be with you to share this presentation. This really was a wonderful opportunity for a large group of us at DOE, and so I'm grateful to be the messenger on behalf of all of us this morning. So as you just heard from Superintendent Conway, as you heard from Secretary Smith earlier this morning, and we'll hear yet again from you later this afternoon, the development of the Secretary's priorities and the DOE strategic plan have been rooted in and refined by deep engagement with our divisions over the last 10 months.

[02:05:29] And so this presentation will provide some insights on the latest iteration of this engagement, and some of the things we learned along the way. So between August and October of this year, the DOE leadership, often accompanied by Secretary Smith, members of the board in some cases, legislators, local dignitaries, and even the governor, visited 18 schools across the Commonwealth, meeting hundreds of students and dozens of teachers and principals along the way.

[02:05:58] So this slide reflects some of the fun numbers from the tour. And as Superintendent Conway mentioned the focus and priority of these visits were schools serving students furthest from opportunity so of the 15 k-12 schools we visited 10 were federally identified either comprehensive support improvement targeted support improvement or additional targeted support improvement we'll be talking about those identifications a lot today so along the way we saw every type of learning environment from toddler classrooms teaching students how to explore the world around them to high school automotive tech classrooms helping 11th and 12th graders explore life

[02:06:37] opportunities after high school so overall we traveled uh 1878 miles uh in support of meeting our students teachers and principals um we saw as you'll hear a lot of high quality instruction in action everywhere we went so all of those miles took us to all eight superintendents regions we saw daycares elementary middle and high schools as well as an innovation center in winchester and you can see here which of those was or is federally identified either last year or this

[02:07:13] year for additional support and as we jump in i will take the opportunity here to thank all the centers schools teachers principals who set aside time to host us welcomed us into their classrooms and took time out of their days to partner with us to share their experiences and their feedback.

[02:07:36] So in Region 1, the team visited a daycare center and an elementary school in Peterson, Petersburg, excuse me, along with Superintendent Brown and her team, and had the opportunity to have some really honest conversations about the challenges teachers in Petersburg face in their day-to-day as they serve their students, in this case some of their youngest students. In Region 2, there were three elementary visits and at least one pair of virtual reality glasses which you can see there along with dinner with the region two superintendents a few of which are very new to

[02:08:12] their roles here in virginia and so in these school visits we saw firsthand the work of some of our literacy coaches and how they're supporting teachers in delivering high quality english and and literacy instruction.

[02:08:30] In region three, we joined the recently appointed superintendent Pankratz to visit some of their classrooms with some of their young learners at an elementary school there. And again, there was a real emphasis on seeing how the Virginia Literacy Act is building strong readers as teachers are getting the supports around the science of reading and implementing their high quality instructional materials for literacy and language arts.

[02:08:59] Then in Region 4, Governor Spanberger joined the team for a visit to a Prince William High School, after which the DOE team went out to see the Innovation Center in Winchester, which you have likely heard about. But in both places, we were able to see and join students in hands-on learning, in automotive tech shops, and in healthcare classrooms, and see in action those students exploring pathways ahead of them after high school.

[02:09:29] In Region 5, we had the opportunity to see a unique dual language program in Harrisonburg, which had some incredible instruction happening in both English and Spanish with elementary students there. And then we were able to do some visits in Waynesboro and have dinner with the Region 5 superintendents after that.

[02:09:52] In Region 6, we joined the Roanoke City team for a deep dive in their focus on high quality instruction. And the team actually got to join some middle school teachers in one of their professional

learning community sessions as they were dissecting data together and then were watching in action as their coaches helped them turn that information into actual refinements in their instructional practices for the remainder of the quarter.

[02:10:17] So it was neat to be able to see that side of the instructional support rather than just watching them deliver that instruction to students. In Region 7, the team visited a really unique regional therapeutic and academic school that was created in partnership with multiple divisions and agencies. And then the team was able to join some elementary students who were doing coding in their art class, living into those computer science standards of learning across the curriculum.

[02:10:50] And then they got to observe the power of a math coach who was supporting a teacher in her classroom as well. And then last but not least, in Region 8, we had the opportunity to visit a Nottoway elementary school with our Virginia Teacher of the Year from Nottoway County and connected with some middle schoolers in Prince Edward, where we were also able to see some of the ways that the Virginia Literacy Act is playing out at the middle school level in particular and the supports being provided to students there. So as we reflect on the visits and the conversations that were had

[02:11:25] with the early childhood leaders, superintendents, central office leaders, principals, teachers, there were a couple observations and key takeaways from that. First and foremost, the progress and the commitment in our federally identified schools is really remarkable.

[02:11:43] We see the progress that they are making being reflected in the SPSF results that you'll hear more about this afternoon but to see that in action was really inspiring um we observed uh in many different places really a laser focus on high quality instruction making sure the materials are aligned and targeting supports to students and that really having impact on their progress in every corner of the commonwealth and then i'll just note the in the discussions um with all of those that we met along the way there was this clear and kind of shared commitment around some shared priorities that I think you heard reflected in the Secretary's comments and remarks this

[02:12:22] morning. And we'll hopefully hear from us as well later this afternoon. But these ideas around expanded early learning, cultivating great educators, and equipping our students with the resources that they need to improve their learning and set them up for success. So you'll hear more about those priorities in our next presentation. But I will just reiterate again that the strong schools tour in addition to the listening tour that was done in the spring really helped us continue to refine and affirm this shared work together and the shared priorities that have emerged both for the secretary and for the doe and i imagine for you all as well

[02:13:00] so with that i'm happy to answer any questions you may have superintendent i have one chief of the almost 2000 miles driven who was the best driver just i don't think any speeding tickets were required so noted so in all serious my question is of the of the 10 federally identified schools and i appreciated you calling out some of the things

[02:13:33] you've seen was there one consistent theme you saw across those schools that may not be reflected in either this data point or in the photos just a takeaway um i think the clearest thing to me and superintendent conway feel free to jump in here too um was the laser focus of all the school leaders on moving instruction and using the data in their buildings to refine and improve their practices and a deep culture of understanding where every student is and what collectively needed to happen

[02:14:12] to help that student succeed um that shone bright to me i'm very clearly in some of the visits yeah i agree with with chief coy and and i think what struck me in particular when we were in the the tidewater region is is this idea that just because it's been this way something hasn't worked or someone hasn't demonstrated a capacity does not mean that that's their destiny and so with as we we explored at a sort of high need elementary school, the transformation around the Virginia Literacy Act and supporting a relatively, not brand new,

[02:14:49] but relatively new educator who was about to go on to performance improvement plan. And there was kind of, you know, there's always this question around him, you know, is it about the resources that educator has received? Is it about the motivation? Like, you know, there's probably a variety of factors that led to that.

[02:15:08] But with the support of getting training and support, as we talked about earlier, for those school leaders, for that assistant principal and that principal to be versed in the science of reading, as well as how to effectively use that high-quality instruction materials.

[02:15:25] And then with the coach, who was really helping that educator take the curriculum, get it out of the box, and practice doing it, that this educator had gone from somebody who they considered potentially a performance issue to somebody that they wanted, you know, the secretary and the superintendent to see in action. And so I just, I think that's so important as we think about what Chief Coy described as like this focus and then this idea of setting high aspirations, because it can be done. This did not need to be a teacher who we were moving out, but instead aligning the resources, making sure the leaders were prepared to support her,

[02:16:04] then really helping her deliver the instruction that could make a difference for kids and I just think that you know as we go into this work around higher expectations and this focus on kids students and educators furthest from opportunity knowing that we have to set those high aspirations but also have to think about supports for educators and leaders to deliver thank you I guess as a follow-up to that did you I guess were there any trends around like newness or new leaders new principals new teachers that would obviously impact the things that you're saying

[02:16:41] around just consistently being able to do those things um i would say i mean what is that line around sort of when something is a bug versus a feature i think sort of some level of turnover is now a feature of our system and and that might be something that you don't like me saying out loud um because we would like it to not be that way but i think between you know we looked around the room you know a third of the room when we were at the superintendent's conference this week is new within the last three years think about the turnover rates of principals and assistant

[02:17:16] principals it's higher and what that then means mathematically is that the tenure that you sit as an assistant principal right is shorter to become a principal and and and similarly you often have less time in the classroom before you become an ap um and then you know we continue i think we have you know uh we've really reduced the teacher vacancies but we are still uh facing challenges on on on on retaining educators you know for longer periods of time and so i think there wasn't president eschen a clear trend except that it was everywhere and really think about you

[02:17:50] know particularly you know sort of what are the supports how do we help you know our leaders truly become instructional leaders not just you know in charge of running buildings and then how do you sort of support folks to improve again using that example from tidewater where you rather than

this teacher going on a performance plan but to be able to help her improve her practice means that you then have someone who's been there three years right has relationships with that community has relationships with other folks in the building so it's that is a better alternative than starting

[02:18:25] from scratch with a brand new teacher and i think it's that type of project that is is is going to going to be, and sort of thinking about how do you make sure that we design interventions that recognize turnover is not a unique thing, unfortunately, but is a fairly commonplace phenomenon.

[02:18:43] Thank you for that. I think, you know, thinking about the priority around talent that was shared by the secretary and then just thinking, like, if you have, I think you said this, like you have the materials, you have the resources, but teachers brand new, and then they're new year after year, That requires a different level of support and just innovation to be able to close the gaps, particularly in our schools and divisions that have the most promise.

[02:19:11] Any other questions around the back to school tools? Okay. Are you off the hot seat? No. Okay. You're not off the hot seat. Okay. So we'll now move to item C, discussion of review of the Virginia Department of Education strategic plan.

[02:19:30] Yeah. So before Chief Coy and Director Echol began, just wanted to take a moment to level set on the why here. Very appreciative to Dr. Smith, who in partner with the Department of Education has been on these tours, you know, in the state.

[02:19:49] In addition to that, obviously has done a lot of work to align with Governor Spanberger on what she would like to see happen over the next few years in education. in Virginia. Upon agreeing to step into this role in January, I think recognize the importance of having a roadmap for the next few years as a way to both open up the agency to insights, feedback from a broad set of stakeholders, or what they would like to see happen over the next few years,

[02:20:27] as well as a tool to organize folks internally around how to execute on that for those of you who are familiar with some of the work that we have accomplished in early childhood there was always a plan um and i think kind of you know in and whether or not it's published or final it was always an ever-changing plan but you know since my time in virginia trying to use kind of different mechanisms to solicit feedback, organize leaders, organize teams with this very clear

[02:21:03] question of what do we want to be different as a result of our work and how will we work backwards from there? And so with that mindset in mind, and I should note if you look back, it's, you know, Dr. Wilson might remember this. If you were to go look back at slides from 2018 and 2019, there'd be an eerie similarity between what we were proposing would happen in the world of early childhood and what we sort of, where we are today. But with that in mind, once Chief Coy, Chief Berta, the secretary, and the leadership team heard from the field loud and clear on the

[02:21:39] Commonwealth Listening Tour, that they, in order for us to be good partners and for our, from our early childhood providers, to our school divisions, to our families, who are kids first and most important educators, in order for them to partner with us, they needed to know what we were trying to achieve. And so what Chief Coy and the team have pulled together over the course of the last eight months kind of reflects all of those insights, some even additional engagement that she has led kind of with stakeholders, and then provides, here's where we're going. And it really

[02:22:18] tries at its heart to kind of recognize the very many many many stakeholders at play right the different priorities so you'll see each of the eight of the of the secretary's priorities reflected in here we are very conscious of what is we have heard so far is important to the board you know we've engaged all of our 131 superintendents on sort of what matters most to them as they think about their constituencies and their board. And what it tries to do is simplify, pull that together to kind of set out a very high-level roadmap for the next few years. It also, as Chief Coy will

[02:22:55] describe, really helps us organize internally. It's a big agency, about 550 employees, right, who are located across the Commonwealth. And sometimes when you hear the very high-level priorities whether that's from the secretary or from the governor um you know thinking about what does that mean for each of those employees can be the gap and so as we thought about in this conversation we had earlier i'm like what do we start what do we stop what do we sustain the strategic plan kind of represents you know a manifestation of that of really trying to think through with the resources we have at our disposal our you know our you know are the incredible

[02:23:33] talent within the department of education the funds that we oversee the policies and procedures this is our best attempt at trying to kind of turn that into a solid road map that we can all measure ourselves against i will say this both represents extraordinary work and it will probably change tomorrow and that will be and if there's anything that defines you know the the early childhood work over the last eight years that i've helped lead in virginia it's the same way right where there's always been this true north but also you know as we kind of you know make the most of each day and sort of ask ourselves and you heard dr smith talk about continuous improvement

[02:24:13] there's two lines you'll always hear from me number one feedback is a gift and we open ourselves up for today so this is not etched in stone and number two is each of us can be a little bit better tomorrow than we are today and so that idea of this is where we are this will help us organize ourselves and manage up and sideways and in partnership with stakeholders. And it is also constantly likely to change if there's a way to improve what we're doing for kids, for educators, and for communities across the Commonwealth. With that, I'll turn it to Chief Coy. Wonderful. Well, thank you, Superintendent Conway. That was a beautiful setup for the

[02:24:49] presentation this afternoon. We'll share a bit about our approach to drafting the strategic plan and our objectives in doing so, share the core components of the plan, including revised mission and vision statements, core values of the agency, and then a bit about our four different priority areas. So as you just heard from me in our back to school tour and you just heard from Superintendent Conway, we continue to intentionally seek feedback from a wide variety of partners, divisions, our own internal staff in order to build this plan. Over the last eight or 10 months or so,

[02:25:28] we have heard over and over about the need for and value in an agency-wide strategic plan that sets clear and durable vision, a set of strategic priorities designed to achieve key outcomes, and coherent aligned structures and processes that guide the agency's day-to-day operations.

[02:25:49] so all of these inputs have guided our thinking about the need for a strategic plan and the manner in which we sought to build it in july we launched a formal development of this plan that will obviously set the direction for the next few years and in order to ensure that we were creating a durable and meaningful plan that was not just it is not just a document on the shelf we began by hiring a director

of strategic initiatives grace eckle who is here at the podium with me today. And I am thrilled to introduce you to her. She'll be presenting the bulk of this

[02:26:25] presentation. But by way of introduction, I will just note that Grace comes to us most immediately from the Virginia Early Childhood Foundation, where she served as a senior advisor working on strategic initiatives, policy, and innovative partnership, and has a background working in state government, where she previously served at the Colorado Department of Early childhood, and as a senior analyst in the office of Governor Polis there. She has a master's in public health and a bachelor's in public policy from UVA, and I will say has the patience of a

[02:26:58] saint. She has dealt with many Friday afternoon senior leadership teams as we have iterated and iterated on this plan, kind of incorporating more and more feedback that we have heard along the way. She has jumped in with two feet. I think on her first day, I threw her into a small group strategic planning discussion and has really thoughtfully captured and developed iterative processes to capture feedback from our many, many stakeholders.

[02:27:29] And so she has then sought, and I think you, as you will see, really truly achieved this task that we've put before her in capturing all of that feedback into a coherent plan that reflects the many different things that we've heard along the way.

[02:27:49] So with that, I'm going to turn it over to Grace to lead you through the rest of the slides. Well, thank you, Chief Boy, for that introduction, and thank you to the members of the board for allowing me to join you today. Again, my name is Grace Echel. I'm the Director of Strategic Initiatives at the Virginia Department of Education. I'm pleased to share with you today the work that's been underway over my past five months here, as well as to preview with you the

[02:28:22] current version of the VDOE strategic plan. I want to start off by expressing our appreciation to the many internal and external partners that have shared their time, expertise, and feedback with us over the past months of developing the strategic plan from informing to developing and refining. We grounded our strategic plan in the current realities of children, students, educators, families, and communities, as well as divisions across all regions of Virginia.

[02:28:57] The key needs and opportunities identified through the more than 2,200 Commonwealth Listening Tour participants last spring, as well as the back-to-school tours at the 17 diverse learning environments this fall directly informed the VDOE strategic plan. As we developed the VDOE strategic plan, we wanted to honor the work and progress that has been made over the past years and to balance aspiration with the on-the-ground realities of operations. We engage staff through

[02:29:32] working groups and an all-agency staff survey with over 200 responses to help develop the framework for the BDOE vision, mission, values, and key priority areas. Through this process, we've had reach and representation from all video branches and divisions and we were extremely grateful for the 30 bipartisan expert advisors that participated on the superintendent transition advisory committee facilitated by the hunt institute who provided early input and direction for the current version

[02:30:06] of the strategic plan we are now in the phase of refining the strategic plan based on the input and feedback of external stakeholders gathered through presentations to groups and more than 90 survey responses our external engagement reflects the full spectrum of videoe's work spanning from early childhood k-12 special education higher education and workforce and includes a variety of diverse

perspectives educators leadership superintendents school board members families students and more through this stakeholder engagement our hope is that everyone involved

[02:30:45] in advancing student outcomes both our internal staff across all corners of the agency and our external partners can see their role in advancing the strategic priority areas that we've laid out for the next four years through the past months of engagement we have developed the bdoe strategic plan framework that defines our vision mission values and priorities we set our vision to describe what we want to be true in the future. Our VDOE vision is every Virginia learner achieves their

[02:31:23] full potential. We use our mission to describe how VDOE will move towards the future vision. The mission of the VDOE is to ensure high quality education across Virginia that empowers every learner to thrive, supports educators and staff, and engages families and communities as essential partners. We set our core values to guide how we will act along the way. Our VDOE values are excellence, integrity, learner focus, collaboration, and purpose. We used our priorities to focus

[02:32:03] and prioritize the actions that matter most to achieve our vision and mission. We have four priority areas. Expand early learning, cultivate educators and environments, resource students and systems and strengthen operational excellence through our staff strategic plan survey we were thrilled that almost all 99 of staff saw themselves in one or more of these four priority areas for each of the priority areas we then defined the key goals identified strategies to advance those goals

[02:32:41] determine and determined how to measure progress which we'll review on the next slides our first priority is expand early learning all children have access to affordable high quality early care and education that prepares them to enter kindergarten the key outcome describes the measurable change that we are working towards by 2030. for priority one this is to increase the share of children receiving high quality publicly funded early care and education our goals on the

[02:33:18] the left hand side describe the future that we envision by 2030. For priority one these are that all eligible families have access to affordable high quality early care and education that more states statewide are meeting or exceeding the state's quality rating and improvement expectations and all children enter kindergarten ready to learn. Along the way we will measure the progress of our strategies towards our goals by monitoring key metrics which are on the right hand

[02:33:49] side these measures cut across all goals and strategies for priority one measures include growth and access to high quality early learning as reflected by participation affordability site quality and kindergarten readiness and on the next slide we'll go into the strategies which align to these three goal areas our strategies are the essential actions that we will take to reach each goal as we move towards implementing the strategic plan the next phase in our process we will be

[02:34:28] developing operational plans that break down specific activities that are necessary to advancing the strategies the strategies for priority one align with with each of the three goals on the prior slide so those are the ones listed in orange across the top the strategies include but are not limited to updating child care payment rates increasing state funding to expand early care and education access, strengthening efforts to reduce turnover and retain high-quality early educators, assisting programs statewide and maximizing capacity while maintaining quality,

[02:35:05] and expanding services for young children with disabilities. The next is priority two, cultivate educators and environments. For this one, the goal is all students have access to well-prepared educators,

quality instructional materials, and safe and supportive learning environments that foster student achievement well-being and lifelong success again the key outcome defines the measurable change we're working toward by 2030. for priority two this is to improve statewide

[02:35:44] student math and literacy outcomes as measured by statewide three through eight assessments k through eight screeners and high school end of course assessments our goals again describe the future that we envision by 2030. for priority two these focus on standards and materials assessment and accountability environments and supports and post-secondary pathways as we work toward our 2030 goals we will measure progress of our strategies by monitoring key

[02:36:16] metrics including increase in schools implementing strong instruction improving supports and boosting well-being advancing employment enlistment or enrollment student ready outcome enrollment student outcomes and specifically this includes reduced frequency of schools re-identified for targeted support and improvement or comprehensive support and improvement as well as improvement in school performance and support framework results among schools that receive goal improvement grant

[02:36:52] funds on the next slide we'll go through the strategies that align to these four goals in orange so again our strategies are the essential actions that we will take to reach each goal under the goal of standards and materials strategies include strengthening instructional vision improving materials implementation and monitoring enhancing educator pipelines and licensure and setting expectations for balanced digital analog resources and responsible ai use

[02:37:26] within the goal of assessment and accountability the strategies include developing an agency-wide school improvement plan aligning funding to highest needs schools building tools and capacity for data-driven improvement and establishing mechanisms to assess impact under this goal is where the important and ongoing work around SPSF the assessment RFP and SOL cut scores will continue to be prioritized the goal of environments and supports includes strategies that expand

[02:38:02] student well-being strengthens educators skills and behavioral health and classroom management and promotes modernized safe and healthy learning environments and finally within the goal of post-secondary pathways the strategy is include expanding early access to high quality career pathways strengthening work-based and dual credit opportunities and improving access for adult learners seeking meaningful credentials. The next is priority three: resource students and systems.

[02:38:38] All students benefit from a strengthened education system in which resource allocation aligns with strategic priorities and relies on data to efficiently and effectively improve learning and outcomes. The measurable change we are working towards by 2030 is learner outcomes improve as funding allocation increases for priority three these goals focus on funding and resource optimization governance and partnerships and data and system modernization along the way to 2030 we will

[02:39:14] measure progress of our strategies towards our goals by monitoring reduction in unspent funds and the increase in data aligned needs-based resource allocation across divisions on the next slide we'll go through the strategies that align to these goals the strategies for priority area three align with each of the three goals from the prior slide under funding and resource optimization the strategy is focused on maximizing all available funding for improved student outcomes

[02:39:50] both through agency support to divisions and agent internal agency processes within the goal of governance and partnerships the actions include supporting the board with setting standards of quality building diverse partnerships and modernizing the school funding formula and under data and systems modernization the strategies include establishing strong data data-driven decision-making practices modernizing priority data systems and strengthening the

[02:40:24] agency's capacity for timely use of data to drive decision-making and resource allocation and finally our last priority area priority four strengthen operational excellence all stakeholders receive consistent coherent and high quality agency service resources and information the measurable change we're working toward by 2030 for priority four is bdoe is recognized as among the top state education agency in the nation a top state agency to work for in virginia and

[02:41:03] a supportive and effective partner to all school divisions. Our goals focus on agency processes, internal and external communication, and agency workforce. Along the way, we will measure progress of our strategies by monitoring metrics of growth in documented processes within the agency, improved partner trust, higher satisfaction scores, and decreased unplanned turnover.

[02:41:31] the essential actions that we'll take to reach each goal for this priority area for include strengthening internal standards and training improving cross-agency coordination and communication enhancing workforce systems and readiness and building talent pipelines to support long-term organizational continuity that takes us through the videoe strategic plan framework and priority areas as you can see from the timeline we are nearing the release of the

[02:42:11] final video strategic plan targeting the end of november we will then move into the implementation of the strategic plan with planning for that beginning in december and then the launch in quarter one of the new year i appreciate getting to share with you all the process for developing our strategic plan as well as the current version of our strategic plan we look forward to keeping the board up to date on our progress and working together to improve education outcomes across

[02:42:42] Virginia. Thank you. Wonderful. Thank you, Grace and Chief Coy. Grace always gets concerned when she has to present because I'm constantly giving her copies afterwards as this is continually iterating. But I hope as you see just trying to kind of take what is very high level and organize it into discrete priorities with those outcomes described at a high level and then I think Mr. Robinson as you were asking about earlier what some of those

[02:43:21] implementation metrics would look like how would we you know ultimately student outcomes is the most important measure but you do need good proximate metrics along the way that that sort of show progress being made in implementation And so I just appreciate all the thoughtfulness that has gone into this.

[02:43:42] I think you'll also see throughout this, you can kind of do a crosswalk of what Secretary Smith shared this morning, the alignment around the early childhood. I think a lot of what you saw in terms of teaching and learning, supports for the educator and leader workforce, accountability assessment, wraparound services, pathways in that second priority we've gone through various permutations of this and at points we pull them apart but then we just recognize there's so many interdependencies and wanting to kind of keep that student

[02:44:18] experience at the core of this i think on the resource um priority there's kind of two aspects of this in which we're working in parallel as dr smith noted is a top priority for the governor to work with the general assembly around modernizing the k-12 funding formula i think as we mr mr mr robinson referred to this earlier i think as we look to the next few years we also know that there is a possibility of limited resources and so really thinking through as an agency in

[02:44:55] partnership with the field how do we shift from an orientation which is an important orientation around we got to spend every dollar and make sure that the way that we spend every dollar is in line with the federal or state requirements attached to it that is a necessary but not sufficient and what we're really trying to do when you think about how we will collect gather make sense of data is to be able to say that this is the highest and best use of dollars right beyond just complying on the spend and the allowable uses and i think to use dr smith's word that's the idea of value add and really thinking through how do we do that with every dollar that comes

[02:45:34] through the VDOE. And as you'll hear about from Dr. K. Wyatt and Deputy Superintendent Hyslop later, right, even with some of the improvement grants, right, going from, you know, the measure of success being like, do we get out the door and do we follow the rules to be like, did this actually deliver the best possible outcome? So it seems like a simple priority or priority three, but it is in fact not when you think about the agency transformation necessary there and then ultimately when we think about as dr smith ended with you know supporting virginia to be nation

[02:46:09] leading means that you need a state education agency that is poised to be expert when necessary poised to hold that high bar right and support and think about what supports are necessary what sort of offers the most value add to helping folks deliver it and tell that story as you see there's some internal work that we want to make sure is substantively in motion um as we think about our uh four-year tenure and what we can how we can you know ideally everybody sitting in in my seat is sort of how do i make sure i leave the agency in a better place um you know than when i came in

[02:46:45] and that should be true you know as being good stewards of these roles so i think you'll see that kind of alignment and again with what kind of makes our strategic plan uh uh slightly uh different as it just starts to get into how does this change sort of translate into the day-to-day work of the 550 employees of the virginia department of education so thank you so much to chief chloe and to director echo thank you board members you have questions i just have one i appreciate um all of the different stakeholders that were engaged early on in the process and one

[02:47:23] one of the things that I know I feel is critical is that we close that feedback loop. And I didn't quite see it on the timeline, but as you progress forward, I'm certain that you're thinking about what that communication loop back is, but I would also at some point, when appropriate, love to hear an update on how that, because we want to bring our stakeholders along and not only let them know that the listening wasn't performative to check a box, but that there was an intentional and deliberate action as a result and so i just wanted to name that i didn't see it clearly here which i know you're still it's evolving but just wanted to make a footnote

[02:47:59] thank you for that that feedback it's so important to keep everyone um engaged and um really respect their time and input dr wilson thank you so i thank you all for this presentation and for the work that's gone into getting it to this point i have a question that is kind of weedy so i I apologize. And then the

second is an observation. So the question is, on Priority 2, slide 13, there's a note here under post-secondary pathways, improving access for adult learners to re-engage

[02:48:34] in education and earn meaningful credentials. Is the early idea that there would be some partnerships established perhaps with community colleges? I don't mean to suggest that, but just asking questions or is there some intent around that that we know of just yet or it's still in process still in process okay um both partnerships with our community colleges but also leveraging that this small but mighty team at doe that engages adult learners and supports them through some federal grants uh to to earn credentials even high school credentials got it okay thank you that's

[02:49:14] helpful um and then my general observation is um the balance that you all are striking with this strategic plan and it also alludes to the comments that secretary smith made thinking about the governor's priorities the secretary's priorities the board of education's comprehensive plan when we get to that revising that thinking about the constituents and those that we've that you all have reached out to as well as the operational the the strategic visionary and operational work that the department is poised to do and so just acknowledging that that fulcrum that has to exist

[02:49:51] among those various uh entities is no small feat and the work that you all have laid out here is incredibly substantive and so appreciate that leaning in to all of the things that must be at least addressed, identified, acted upon so that by 2030 this North Star that we're reaching for is in clearer or in clearest view as it can be in 2030 and then even beyond. So thank

[02:50:23] you for this. Bridges and then Mr. Robinson. Okay. Yeah, no, I appreciate that, Dr. Wilson, and I think reflecting on President Ashton's question from earlier today, I mean, one important insight that i would add upon reflection from the secretary's presentation and as you have this in front of you is um the willingness to stay the course where um where the initiative or effort is is good for students and i think um what you know that in

[02:51:02] some ways uh although board president ashton makes a really important point around the need to kind of think about what you stop versus uh you know what you start i mean there is very much a commitment to sustain bipartisan priorities that are showing promise for kids and so whether that's the virginia literacy act or it's accompanying high quality instructional materials law whether that's a recognition that in a bipartisan way jlark supported you know that said the the school performance and support framework was fundamentally sound but you needed a set of

[02:51:39] of thoughtful uh shifts over time and i think that's really important in in many situations when you think about something as big as the videoe and as large as our public early childhood and education system the thing that takes the longest time is starting over from scratch um and so we've just this this plan as as does the governor and the secretary's priority try to reflect if there is a way to make it bipartisan, to connect it to the real insights and feedback from stakeholders, and to think about what is good for kids, regardless of what seat you sit

[02:52:16] in, has just been very intentional on this. And I think that's important, and hopefully we can sort of model that as we as we move forward. I'm not sure the word Dr. Ruggies or Mr. Robinson jump in. That was me trying to do our right paper system. Thank you so much for the presentation. It's lovely to have you grace um i have three comments slash questions and um from the weeds to the big

[02:52:47] picture i'll start with the big picture which is um capacity um an agency of 550 employees and by my rough count 48 strategies um with i didn't even add up the measures and the outcomes And so I have no sense other than my historical perspective from having worked at the agency back in the day and hearing anecdotally that it used to be a whole lot bigger than it is even today.

[02:53:17] So I'm wondering if there, do we have any benchmarks of like actual employees in VDOE compared to other state agencies, compared to the numbers of student schools and school systems to get a sense of where we are in the realm of, you know, even operational structural capacity, let alone getting to the place of resources.

[02:53:42] I'm not aware of them, but if y'all are, I would love to hear more about that, just thinking about that issue. But I'm always very cognizant of, you know, what's the capacity to do all these wonderful things? Where might you need support to build capacity to do all these things?

[02:54:02] So, I think that's a great question. I am, again, having had the opportunity to spend multiple years in different state education agencies and, you know, having the opportunity over those 15 years to connect with other states, you know, I think we can certainly go back and look at kind of how we compare.

[02:54:25] spend a lot of time yeah but i think i think the bigger issue and i and and this is not covered here but has been a work in parallel as as you think about what we have done with trying to stabilize our senior leadership and then there has been very intentional work with senior leaders around what their org chart looks like underneath that um you've if you've heard me talk about organizational charts before which i know i talked with some of you about in january i think there's sort of two two guiding principles for for me as a leader in that work you know number one

[02:54:59] is a shift to organize by function right rather than just like funding source or what constrains you and that's a big shift like i mean i remember the most distinctive example of this is when people like name the building after title one and you're like i don't really think that was the intent or the person right and again you know that's that's that's something but really thinking through what are we trying to achieve and how do you organize as an agency to do that um most say education agencies are not in that place right and so as you think about kind of being nation-leading that would be a necessary and then i think the other piece is the kind of the

[02:55:35] continual evolution i would imagine to board president ashton's point earlier that thinking about from a in the weed staffing perspective of stopping certain things that we do not think are value add um and uh uh you know sort of looking at how we would switch that is important so we'll talk about it a little a little bit later today but on the school improvement grants like we can actually save ourselves work if we don't have to review every year but seek to move it to two-year grants and that both works in terms of um it's better for school divisions with a longer planning and execution horizon and it also means that we're not running applications every year so

[02:56:12] So there's like a little bit of win-win there in terms of how we organize. But I would say, Vice President Bridges, I think it is still very much an open question as we sort of get clear on what we want to achieve. And then we sort of look at where we are, our talent, and where we have sufficient capacity and where there are gaps.

[02:56:32] Part of the urgency, and again, full credit goes to Holly and Grace and the broader team on that while we wanted to get this out is so that we would even be able to go into this General Assembly, right?

With some sense of like, here's where we're covered and here's where there are gaps, but that's still very much a work in progress.

[02:56:53] Thank you. So that was big picture one. Big picture item two is how can the board support, in light of the fact that, you know, we don't have oversight over the department or this, So how are y'all thinking about that? You know, how do you report out success and to whom and who can help you with public accountability on that? And where do you see the board's role in?

[02:57:20] That's another great question. So I think the first piece would be, I hope that you see some of your priorities reflected in here, right? And so I think this idea of really wanting, and we spent some time, you know, with Secretary Smith to make sure that priorities of SOE were reflected as we think about some of the really important conversations that we've had over the course of the summer, whether it's talking about the MOU school divisions and improvement, whether we're thinking about accountability and the questions of higher expectations, because we have, even in some your short tenure on the board have dealt with pretty um important topics like making sure that

[02:57:58] although officially um you know that you all do not oversee this plan that seeing the things that you care about in here means that we can um make progress on on executing on them i think we are open on how to bring these things um back and progress on it um you know i'll give an example in the world of early childhood, we do, you know, periods, we've done an annual dashboard on sort of progress and high level metrics. And then we've also done a state of the state. And so kind of really, those are sort of two examples. And so we, you know, as you reflect on what could be helpful

[02:58:36] for you all, what would be useful to see, those are just examples of just thinking about how we create a mechanism to ensure that we come back and say, here's where it's working, here's where there are challenges here's where we're suggesting shifts um either in in in priorities uh or goals or sort of uh strategies based on what is working and where there are challenges those are those are ones we've used in the past and i would be more than comfortable to have us as a team figure out what we could do to bring it back to you all thank you my last question is so

[02:59:11] technical wonky tiny compared to those um is it possible once again now to just in the in to support your transparency goal for the public to see who to contact in the agency and be able to actually reach those folks because that's that's back yes okay okay there are uh there is a new some new contact us information on our website but as we think about the interconnections with this strategic plan can help make that even more clear in light of this plan as well.

[02:59:45] Okay, good. Thank you so much. Mr. Robinson? Well, first of all, this is so exciting. Thank you for all the thoughtful work that's gone into building on the listening and learning to get a plan in place before the 27 legislative session and have it be bold. I love the language throughout here on prioritizing our highest needs, schools, divisions, and students. You see that reflected in multiple priorities, and that's deeply appreciated. I also love both the attention, as we talked about, to approximate metrics, but the start of these 2030 key outcome pieces that

[03:00:22] you have here. And so I just want to cheerlead as you continue to work on those 30 outcomes and think about knowing that some of this is out of your BDOE by self-control, but in partnership with the secretary's office, the government's office, the legislature, and our community partners.

[03:00:38] I just love the language I've heard today around nation leading. And as we think about that key outcome for priority one, it's not just the amount of students receiving the early care and education. I love that increase, but it's like what percentage are truly kindergarten ready? And what's that measure? How are you doing something truly nation leading in the 30 outcome on achievement?

[03:01:03] and so my first uh question would then be about priority three um right now that key outcome is learner outcomes improve as funding increases i i think there's something that you we want learning outcomes for sure in priority two and priority three i'm wondering what the the bigger thing for us to put in a dashboard and to go towards and one thing that i've heard a lot of today which i love is this ROI piece and how that's part of funding and resource optimization. And it just makes me

[03:01:37] think, you know, the secretary mentioned high-dosage tutoring earlier. We made a heavy investment in high-dosage tutoring as a state a few years ago. We have in our board comprehensive plan to track a return on investment on that. And so I guess it's a dual observation and question about priority three like what might be the big uh outcome there uh but also uh not to add another strategy uh but you are we holding ourselves to naming what have we learned from the big investments

[03:02:13] we've made uh whether it's high dosage tutoring vla lab schools etc uh so that as we make our next resource decisions we're building off of those lessons um that's a great question i mean i think

[03:02:31] I think in general, that's exactly the shift that we're looking to achieve, right, as you think about the kind of the return on investment and what are the proximate measures, right? So if you think about something like high dosage tutoring, how many students participated, you know, of those students, you know, what were students who would be sort of considered, you know, at a vulnerable subgroup, whether that was economically disadvantaged or a student with disability or an English language learner, and then thinking, you know, ultimately, did we sort of get them to a level of proficiency or even more granular, how far do we move them? And I know

[03:03:08] we've talked a lot as a system around really thinking through what it would take to be able to kind of fully measure that growth from one year to the next, or even from when you start school to when you finish the school year and thinking through how you would put a system in place that would not only capture those proximate measures, but would ultimately have that impact.

[03:03:35] And it's hard, right? I mean, currently our system is pretty binary in terms of the focus on, you know, proficient or not. And so as we think through these measures, how do we do that? I think we have a solid base on the kind of, you know, the numbers, right? Like the number of students in the lab schools, the number of students who received the learning acceleration grants, right? The number of students who participated in high dosage tutoring I think where we don't have the systems in place and where I know we've got folks like Chief Berta and Deputy Superintendent McCleary working on is

[03:04:10] how do you capture that information because that that of all of the places and I can't you know in terms of uh Vice President Bridges your point about capacity the foundation and the thing that as I come out of the early childhood work and look at sort of the broader VDOE is you know from almost the beginning of the you know the 2018 strategic plan for early childhood was about here we're trying to achieve and we kind of made sure along the way to build the capacity through link b5 and the va connects and the ready regions to like make sure that we could capture the data

[03:04:45] all the stuff in way you know in candor you know all you know we we are there there has not been the sufficient investment in the past in that place we you know both in terms of the staff support you know to kind of get all of our staff there so that every decision is informed by data and that as you describe mr robinson you're able to say okay here's who we know how many benefited because we often have to report on that for federal state purposes but like what we saw as a result of that intervention or that investment is still um is something we have to build that infrastructure for because it's our priority and as you build that infrastructure i would encourage

[03:05:23] you know uh uh grace you know we haven't had those systems in place uh so we can't name it with deep rigor but we but we have great educators working at the videoe who have good hypotheses on uh and can be as dad driven as the data allows on what we learn so so you know if the legislature is going to consider major investments i just really want them to have a chance to learn from your incredible team on what we think we know um which means me the priority two um as i look at

[03:05:56] the secretary's priorities one could argue i know it's not this simple uh that um perhaps five out of eight of them uh live in priority two uh it also has um the most strategies listed etc and so i i I know number one I just want to like encourage don't let formatting get in the way of like you know if this one needs three slides instead of two or you know just to make sure you know particularly because I think with all the great work that this board did in the past and that

[03:06:35] we're working on now on the SPSF the very exciting presentation we're about to hear on school improvement. I just think as you combine the high quality curriculum standards work with the school improvement work itself, I think is perhaps the most important work in terms of opting for return on investment for students that we have before us. And I just get afraid of it getting lost in this kind of other incredibly important work around post-secondary pathway

[03:07:06] assessment reform etc uh so i i just encourage um you uh you it's so clean priority one um and um and so i i uh encourage us to make sure that we don't let formac in the way of being um bold and ambitious and whether that means we can do five priorities or not i don't i'd leave it to y'all um uh and so that's that and then i didn't see as we talked about prioritizing systems mou listed at all here and we've talked a lot about you know a strategic plan should be about

[03:07:45] what we're seeking to improve and we've named i i think pretty clearly as a state that we're unhappy with the supports we are providing to our most underserved divisions we can take that to to another level. So that's something I see missing. And the final comment, the other thing I see not necessarily missing, but I'm curious about is, you know, the word technology doesn't show up, the word AI only shows up in relation to data systems internally. And so, you know, I love the

[03:08:20] Secretary's language around guidance to humans on how to use the emerging technology. And again, I don't think that work is as critical right now as SPSF, etc. But it's going to become more important each year. And it seems missing in the plan. We do have it, Mr. Robinson, on 13. It's just digital analog. But you can be more clear there. Appreciate that in terms of making sure that we add our divisions in greatest need, which in fact are our memorandum of understanding

[03:08:57] divisions. And so we can be sure to integrate that into the framework. I do also, I failed to mention in my response to the prior question, Mary, your question with Dr. Bridges is we are planning to hire an executive director who will support Director Echol and Chief Coy in thinking about how we're using data strategically to support the execution of

[03:09:21] So they're just, you know, again, you know, as we think about somebody dedicated the same way that Director Echol is dedicated to making this happen, that in order for us to, across the course of this strategic plan, and the very important priorities it embodies, we got to think about where we are in terms of baseline.

[03:09:39] we got to think about what are the various measures that we can we can put in place and that is something that we we do not your question dr bridges currently have the capacity for and so needing to name someone uh and and we have posted for and i plan to hire that position soon right um okay the oh gosh couple thoughts um one thank you uh this is incredibly comprehensive um and it was so comprehensive that a point i just had to start to stop writing notes and then listen um and the the listening part though was just hearing all of the alignment around the

[03:10:18] secretary's priorities from the governor's priorities to where we are now and you know i think the the question i asked the secretary and still resonate with me is like the stop start continue and you know i think i've been here three years it feels like 30 but that being said like we have done a lot of work on this board um with the staff around high quality instructional materials raising the standards systems of accountability um you know we uh the whole spsf which is is things so much has changed so i appreciate the whiplash that the field might

[03:10:57] be having because it felt like whiplash when we were going through it because it was the work we needed to do to raise the bar. And I think the last point of the secretary, and we've said it a lot, is around, we don't want to be at the bottom, and we actually want to lead the nation. And I think because there's this solid foundation around all those things, it is now, what I hear, and I think we are incredibly lucky to have you, superintendent, is just a relentless focus on executing well.

[03:11:27] That's what I hear in this, even with all thousand bullets, is that there's just a focus on we've got to execute very well the high standard that we've set for ourselves as board members, as educators and being responsive.

[03:11:46] And so I just want to applaud you and the team for that, because this is a great college president for William & Mary, I might say, who says, like, sometimes boring is okay. And, you know, there's nothing I'm bringing boring back.

[03:12:02] Yes, bringing boring back is totally fine. And, you know, no news is good news, but actually the steady pace of executing very well is the new hotness, if you'll call it. It's like doing it very well. So, you know, I echo my fellow board members, what you all have done well is communicate well. You've communicated transparently, and I would not want any of that to be lost, is that it's not a value, but transparency is how you have behaved. It's about excellence. It's about our scholars.

[03:12:33] And then the last thing I'll say is, this will all change tomorrow, which is what you said. And so I think to the extent that that is very clear that we don't want to have this plan guide us where we're not responsive to what's exactly in front of us, but still keeping our North Star, our North Star.

[03:12:53] And so I think kudos to you, kudos to the team. And, you know, while there's small tweaks and there's refinements, really to me is about communication and change management for the field and for the staff and even for us board members to make sure that we understand like the why we're doing these things and why things might change because now we have more data or we've actually tried to implement some of these things, but they may need to change.

[03:13:19] i just want to say thank you no no i appreciate that and i think that the the importance of this may all change tomorrow uh just cannot be understated um one of the things i'm very proud of is that you know in our work in early childhood we were able to uh make progress on a goal towards the transformation the pandemic hit right and you know we had to add a second practice year right and we had to sort of figure out how do you first just protect and you know keep the early childhood sector alive and that had to be the priority over kind of moving everything or building out vqb5 or

[03:13:59] link b5 and so i just i've always sort of taken that example of like you can have a very great plan you know but if you know but you you never know what will happen tomorrow and that what i thought served virginia well during the pandemic in the world of early childhoods that we at least had a rough true north of where we wanted to get and so we had to slow down we had to think differently we had to respond to the very real needs of our little learners of our centers and our family day homes and our schools in crisis but knowing what we were trying to achieve you know helped in some ways as we thought about okay how do we make the most of the pandemic dollars how do

[03:14:36] we think about what what matters most in this moment so i think absolutely um that has to be kind of a key asterisk as we think about this work but hopefully by moving urgently on this by reflecting many of the the priorities that were already a priority for this board as well as the secretary and the governor and then noting that and it's great feedback dr maxwell about the sort of then re-engaging the field on here's what we heard here's what we're doing how do you see yourself in it ultimately while we can't control what will happen in the future that it will at

[03:15:11] least hopefully help us stay organized whatever does come our way well thank you very much now there's item d you guys still no do you guys need a break anybody any break no okay we're going to keep going so we're going to now move on to item d the is that that right agency-wide school improvement or something okay agency-wide school improvement okay here we go absolutely so as uh Dr. K. White is coming to the podium. I just want to take a moment. I know we talked a little bit

[03:15:47] about this, and Mr. Robinson reminded us of the importance of this item, but to level set as we think about this work, and you heard this in the words of Secretary Smith this morning, part of, at a very high level, the way in which we will measure ourselves is not only how Virginia does on average but how our students educators and communities furthest from opportunity are doing and when you think about that mission and you think about the recent state law that says that

[03:16:24] called on the department and the superintendent to think differently about school improvement this is not uh just a federal funding source you know in response to a particular challenge but really as an agency how do we think about students and educators classrooms schools furthest from opportunity and how will we as an agency not just maximizing one particular federal funding source but as an agency support year over year uh within year uh improvement and so we are i'm so excited

[03:16:59] to introduce our strategic advisor uh dr k wyatt has extensive experience in our virginia public schools coming to us most recently from alexandria city with all of its diversity opportunities and challenges and has been working closely with myself the department staff as well as a broad set of stakeholders who sometimes will give her the skinny in a way that they may not necessarily trust others on what is working where there are gaps and how to think differently about our supports for schools, educators, and kids in greatest need. And so very pleased to turn it

[03:17:39] over to Dr. Kay Wyatt. Thank you. I don't know about that giving me the skinny, but we'll see how it goes. So good afternoon, President Ashton, Vice President Dr. Bridges, members of the board, and Superintendent Conway. Building on the strategic plan that you just heard, I'm going to zoom in on one strategy within it, and that is the agency-wide school improvement plan. The plan is about how Virginia coordinates its supports for schools and especially those identified schools, including our CSI, our TSI, and our ATSI schools, as well as our MOU divisions, so that support becomes a durable agency-wide function. And our theme, of course, is building

[03:18:17] a sustainable path forward, and our promised two divisions is every school, every division, one path forward. And so next, I would like to take a moment to review our objective and areas to be covered in today's agency-wide school improvement presentation. As soon as I get my clicker working here. There we go. Today I will review VDOE's new mandate and our plan for unifying and strengthening the school improvement efforts across the agency. This is informational. My goal

[03:18:52] is to show you the direction we are heading, the why, which we know the why is important, and the first steps we are taking this year. What you will see is a clear direction and real momentum. And so what we will cover is codifying school improvement, challenge and opportunity, the alignment with accountability, school improvement as a unified experience, the approach, implementation, and measurement, and school improvement within the VDOE strategic plan, which you just heard.

[03:19:19] And so why it matters is that school improvement belongs to all of us. And so let me begin with the law of school improvement that is now written, and I believe our superintendent just mentioned that. Our new state law mandates that the VDOE and the board support school improvement in a comprehensive and impactful manner. There are three shared responsibilities between the superintendent, the department, and the board. The superintendent consistently and effectively implements a state program to support the improvement of low-performing schools based on the accountability standards

[03:19:55] this board sets in the standards of accreditation. And then the department, we are to ensure that we have the right structure and qualified staff in place to provide that support effectively. for the board to ensure that the superintendent and the department administer an effective school improvement program and so what does this mean that this is shared work and with this mandate in place here is what we hope you will take away from our time together so by the end of our time we hope you will leave with four key takeaways first a shared understanding of how school

[03:20:31] improvement in virginia has worked and why this is the right moment to strengthen it second a unifying framework moving from separate compliance-driven activities to one coordinated system that builds capacity in divisions. Third, the path forward. How VDOE will bring its team, its funding, its resources together around one goal and one unified school improvement process.

[03:20:59] And finally, fourth is our partnership. Your accountability decisions determine which schools are identified and this work shapes the support that follows so what you will see is intentional alignment every office in the agency bringing its expertise to the same table for the same schools towards the same goal divisions should feel the difference without having to connect the dots and we are building this with superintendents and principals not for them they know their schools best and our role is to ensure they can access the right supports exactly when they need it.

[03:21:35] And so let me start with the division experience and the challenge we are taking on. So our purpose is simple, it's to strengthen how VDOE supports divisions, so identified schools and ultimately all schools improve outcomes for students.

[03:21:53] So where we have been, the agency previously had siloed offices engaging divisions on separate timelines, similar data requests, and plans built to satisfy a forum rather than drive the real improvement. And what we heard, this did not come from a single meeting, it comes from months of conversations with regional superintendents and with VDOE staff across offices from the Commonwealth Listen and Tour, and I think you heard a little bit about that earlier, with our Secretary of Education and the State Superintendent, and from our own review of agency processes. And all of

[03:22:27] this points to the same challenge as well as the same opportunity. And the listening does not stop here. Stakeholder engagement is one of the work streams of this goal. So superintendents, principals, and teachers and our own staff will continue to shape this work as it is built, not just react to it once it's finished. And so the challenge today is the visions here from multiple VDOE contacts and messages are not always clear or consistent. Processes and timelines and data requests are often separate. That is why a review of our own processes and standard operating

[03:23:03] procedures is also a work stream of this goal. So before we ask divisions to do anything differently, we are looking closely at what we are already asking of them. Removing duplicate steps and data requests, aligning timelines, and making sure each office's procedures work together.

[03:23:23] Also, compliance work crowds out the time that teachers and leaders need for teaching and learning, and we know that that is what matters most. So I want to be clear, our staff work incredibly hard, and so do our divisions. So over more than a decade, the system built to support our schools grew side by side rather than together, and that opportunity is to connect them.

[03:23:46] So what do we want to be different? one coordinated video team with clear communication timely high quality support match the each divisions needs and more time for leaders to focus on teachers and students we're not starting over we are building on what we what already works and it's connecting it to it so that supports are coordinated and builds lasting capacity so where your work and ours meet is the board says the accountability policies and the SPSF identifies which schools need support and VDOE delivers

[03:24:20] coordinated support and the result we all want is improved outcomes for students. When you know meaningful support follows identification, you can make accountability decisions with confidence that will lead to real help for schools. And of course House Bill 924 guides us in this work, but our main reason is simpler. Divisions need a better experience with VDOE so they can give students a better experience so where we are headed this work we're focused on one coordinated one unified team and one planning calendar with less duplicate paperwork and more time for

[03:24:57] implementation coaching and data support built around each division's context and network so no division takes on this challenge alone many of our smaller divisions have central offices of fewer than 10 people and they cannot staff an expert in every area and that is exactly where coordinated state team adds its real value. Virginia teachers are capable as any in the nation, and as we raise expectations for students, we are raising them alongside a full set of supports. And so just a quick personal story before joining the agency. I sat on the other side of this work as a division

[03:25:35] superintendent, so I know what it's like to receive the accountability results and then work out what comes next. Different offices have reached out at different times, sometimes with different messages and different deadlines, and my team spent time on clarion emails and completion of forms that really should have gone to supporting teachers and students, and that experience is a big part of why I care so much about getting this right for every superintendent, principal, educator, student, and every family in Virginia. We need to move to building capacity. Today's school improvement can feel like filling out forms and all of the check boxes, but school improvement should be about

[03:26:15] that, building capacity and less about what goes on paper and more about what educators are doing in schools and in classrooms and how we can help them do that better. So to show how this connects to our accountability work, here is a framework I'm sure you have seen before. So this graphic tells the story of how this work aligns with our other efforts. It grounds our conversation about accountability with the board, legislators, superintendents, and the governor's office, and each part works with the others.

[03:26:49] The standards of learning sets high expectations. State assessments measure how well students meet them. The school performance and support framework measures how well schools support students and identifies those that need help. But today's focus is that fourth piece, the area there that you see in green, the supports and resources.

[03:27:09] That is where agency-wide school improvement lives. Measurement improves outcomes only when meaningful supports follows that identification. So supports and resources are not one's office's jobs. Academic excellence depends on a strong teaching and learning and nearly every part of the agency contributes to it. Whether it's not just the teaching and learning office, it's assessment, accountability, federal programs, populations, student services, and of course school operations. School improvement is where all of that expertise comes together with

[03:27:45] a clear vision and a clear set of next steps. When we pool what we know, divisions get better support with less effort on their part. So your decisions about measures and thresholds determine which schools move into this space, and our role as an agency is to make sure that when a school arrives here, the support is coordinated with, of course, we spoke about this earlier, the evidence based materials, the high quality instructional materials, and it makes a difference. So that is why accountability and support have to work together. So on one side is the accountability.

[03:28:23] The SPSF identifies which schools need support and guides how much support they receive with clear, time-bound expectations for improvement. And on the other side on this chart you'll see is capacity building, professional learning, which we've heard a lot about earlier, data, funding, and regional connection, the resources divisions need to actually change. School improvement is what connects the two. Accountability without support, ask divisions to change without giving them the means. And support without accountability, risk losing sight of a student's outcome.

[03:28:59] And Virginia's model holds both. For superintendents and divisions, this means identification becomes the start of a partnership, not the end of a conversation. The board says the policy levers, VDOE brings the practical support that follows. And when you can trust that meaningful support, follows identification. You can make accountability decisions with confidence. So what will be different? Let me return to the goal that I started with. At the start, I shared the goal of one unified school improvement process, and here's what it means in practice. The end state is simple.

[03:29:36] Divisions spend less time navigating VDOE and more time on teaching and learning that improves outcomes for students. The unified process here has four tenets, and the agency-wide school improvement plan not only shows our commitment, but work streams to support the commitment and shows what the divisions will experience. Under this goal, I want to provide an overview of those four tenets and the impacted workflow. The first one, of course, is the one team. Our commitment, every office that touches school improvement, including teaching and learning and all the others have named federal programs, special populations, I could go on and on, but we are

[03:30:14] working from shared goals backed by senior leadership. The division experience is one clear voice, fewer coordinated messages and webinars. And what it means is a cross-office school improvement team endorsed by senior leadership with a clear charge and shared goals, regular meeting cadence, and clear decision-making. It connects every office that touches the work. And clear communication, as I said, lives here too because those fewer better coordinated webinars and memos so divisions know what is coming and when it's coming. And the

[03:30:49] work streams behind it includes planning and communications, which coordinates that work and leads a regular process of review with senior leadership team, agency specialists, and our communication staff. Our second tenet is one improvement framework and our commitment is one shared way to assess needs, plan, and monitor built on continuous improvement processes. The The division's experience includes one planning calendar, data asked for instead of it being asked for several times, and what this means for divisions is that every identified school gets support with the continuous improvement cycle, assessing their needs, the planning,

[03:31:28] the implementing, and the monitoring with one improvement plan and one calendar, no matter which office or funding sources involved. This is the core of moving from compliance to building capacity and the work stream behind it is the agency work of our process and sop review we will review videoe zone processes and standard operating procedures to remove duplicate steps and data requests and align timelines and resources across offices so divisions excuse me experience a clear manageable framework from the start the third tenet is one funding pathway our commitment

[03:32:07] is one needs-based application and rubric that aligns school improvement funds to what each school plan says it really needs. The divisions experience is a simpler funding process with timelines to plan well. And what this means is a single needs-based application and a rubric for school improvement related funds. So dollars follow what each school plan says it needs.

[03:32:32] We have started this philosophy with our current school improvement grants as of this fall, which you'll hear a little bit about later. And the workstream behind it is just one unified grant pathway. And our last and fourth tenant here is One Resource Hub. It is our commitment to one trusted place to find vetted supports and professional learning matched to need. Virginia already offers a great deal from literacy partnerships to TTAC supports to coaching, but our job is to curate it and match schools in greatest needs to the right supports. The the division experience, the right support,

[03:33:09] with follow-up to see whether it's helping our students. This means one public-facing hub, crosswalk to the strategic plan priorities and our school improvement goals, where divisions find vetted resources and tools, the right contact, and a coordinated professional plan tied to school and division performance levels.

[03:33:30] Divisions will find professional learning matched to their needs with follow-up ensure it is truly having an impact and the work stream behind it is the resource hub and of course professional learning in short this agency-wide school improvement plan and strategic plan goal and tenants will clear the path strengthen the support protect instructional time and deepen learning superintendents will not see a new layer of requirements they will see the agency working as one around schools so this is where we're headed and how we will measure all of this in

[03:34:05] one year we will measure our progress this year by the evidence at each step not by a calendar year alone year one runs from this fall which we've already started through the summer of 2027 and four steps that build on each other and step one we listen we heard and we will continue to hear from divisions regional superintendents educators our own staff and we take an honest look at our own processes. Two work streams lead this step: stakeholder engagement, gathering input from superintendents, principals, teachers, our staff, and the review of our process and standard

[03:34:43] operating procedures so we know which steps to simplify before we build anything new. Today's conversation is part of this step as we share back what we heard and we set our baseline on what we have learned up until this point. And the evidence of this progress is stakeholders were experienced that processes will be less compliance-oriented and more aligned with instructional vision and reflect stakeholder feedback. So what we heard in step one and what our processes and SOPs review finds directly shapes what we were built in step two. So step two,

[03:35:20] we build. We bring the unified team within VDOE together and continue to design the shared framework, the single application, the resource hub with the vision engagement. Evidence of this progress is as we work on the different and interdependent components, school divisions have the opportunity to review components of the unified experience. Step three, we launch. We put the first new supports in divisions' hands and learn from how they use them. Evidence of this progress is divisions are using the application, the hub, and our learning supports. And in step

[03:35:56] four, we reflect and report. We review what worked, adjust to what did not, and set the plan for the year ahead. And evidence of this progress is components of this unified experience are consistently used. Divisions report increased satisfaction and you receive as the board our year-end update covering what we built, what divisions experienced, early results, and the what comes next. I want to be realistic though. This is year one as we're building out this cycle and we will get something meaningful on the ground, learn from it, and grow into year two.

[03:36:33] And each year after that, of course, the cycle will start a little earlier. So please notice that divisions are a part of every step of this process. And so as we transition to the next slide, I want us to think about evidence and each step tells us what we're doing, what the work is.

[03:36:49] The bigger question is whether it's working for divisions and students. And so the strategic plan, sorry.

[03:37:06] So what success looks like is divisions experience one coordinated VDOE and students are identified in schools that are going to improve. And we were gonna ask them two questions and we'll ask two questions of ourselves as we begin this work. Are divisions experiencing one VDOE successfully?

[03:37:24] Each tenant has a simple signal. We just went over them, the one team, the one framework, the one funding path and the one resource hub. And then are students improving? Indicators for the selected

schools are SPSF results for mastery growth and readiness, attendance and graduation, and ultimately schools exiting, CSI, TSI, and ATSI status, and of course, student growth and achievements.

[03:37:49] So some of this evidence is numbers, and some is what superintendents and principals share with us. This data is extremely valuable. We review both together in scheduled meeting cadences with the unified team and senior leaders at the agency.

[03:38:04] Stakeholder engagement continues after launch. Division voice gathered through feedback from superintendents and school leaders is one of our measures, not an afterthought. I heard earlier a little bit about that feedback loop, and this is a part of that process.

[03:38:19] So we measure, review, reflect, and adjust. If divisions tell us we made something more challenging instead of more supportive, we will listen, and we will reflect and make that change and make sure that we know that this is not a static strategy.

[03:38:34] And for the data infrastructure this year, we will use the data we already collected before asking divisions for anything new and keep one shared progress tracker built to inform our decisions, not just to report out. So over time, we will work to connect the application, the improvement plan, the hub, and the data so we can see a school's needs, support that it's used over time, its results, and use those analytics to spot common themes across our schools.

[03:39:04] And so our work is really about alignment to the strategic plan that you heard earlier. And so the strategic plan, of course, our umbrella. It's vision that every Virginia learner achieves their unique potential and it sets the four priorities: school readiness, our learning environment, student achievement, and operational excellence. The agency-wide school improvement plan is one strategy within the greater strategic plan. It is not a separate initiative. Our goal is one unified school improvement process so every identified school and division experiences the one team, the improvement framework, the one pathway funding, and the resource hub. And so how this all connects to

[03:39:43] the strategic plan, this strategy contributes most directly to priority four, which is operational excellence. It's consistent, coherent, high quality service from the agency, but it also advances student achievement by resourcing learners according to their needs. And it strengthens learning environments through professional learning and shared resources for all of our educators. And for a superintendent, here's what it means. When a school is identified, they should not have to search for support from across the agency. Our offices will be ready and willing to

[03:40:19] work from the same goals and speaking with one voice. And so with that goal in mind, here is what we hope you will take away from our time together today. There are four essential ideas. The challenge, divisions navigate separate processes and compliance work crowds out time for teaching and learning and our goal one unified school improvement process with one team one improvement framework one pathway finding and one hub and so how we get there is through these four steps of the listen build launch reflect and report each one is built with divisions through ongoing

[03:40:57] stakeholder engagement and a review of our own processes and procedures and how we will know is the evidence of progress at each step what superintendents and principals tell us student outcomes with a year and update to the board and for divisions it comes down to this a clear path strengthening the supports protecting instructional time and deepening learning for our students so in closing i just want to say this work belongs to all of us we are building it alongside our superintendents our

principals our school leaders and educators who lead this great work every day and we see you of course the board as our partners in this great work so thank you

[03:41:36] thank you very well done superintendent yeah thank you dr k wyatt for um presenting that that big picture and as you heard throughout her presentation just the reflection of the real world experience here um the uh in a in addition to welcoming all the work that went into this um i think as you as you probably heard covered in the strategic plan as you also hear a little bit later in in deputy deputy superintendent heislav's presentation is trying to kind of uh even as we

[03:42:14] look at this big picture and the model and framework that uh dr k white has put in front of us thinking about how do we incorporate the most immediately pieces of this and so uh uh deputy superintendent heislav will talk about you know making sure that the school improvement funds were available immediately after the rollout of the accountability results and that on the back end dr k wyatt was working alongside deputy superintendent heislop deputy superintendent holland's deputy superintendent um profit so that it was fully reflective of uh competitive

[03:42:50] application it wasn't like okay you know this is coming from this particular part of the agency and this is coming from that part of the agency that is still there's still work to be done um as we were looking at there's still lots of other funds outside of the federal school improvement funds like the title funds and the state funds and the t-tac funds and so um you know i think this does a good job of presenting where we want to be and how to think about getting there in a cyclical way that's very iterative and done in partnership with our division central office and building leaders and you'll also hear us hopefully throughout our presentations you know begin to

[03:43:28] incorporate discrete pieces of that even if we can't solve for every dollar going to a CSI school this year kind of coming through that one hub that at least when there are new dollars coming out that we are modeling this with with every uh with every uh effort going to the left first and coming back to you okay mr robinson dr bridges well uh first of all i don't know the correct protocol and when to give standing ovation so i didn't give one uh but uh i am incredibly excited

[03:44:01] about uh the ambition articulated here about one experience reducing compliance having one application and having a hub of support it's a i've seen in states like louisiana and colorado that have moved to uh consolidated funding and and more strategic cross agency support and holding itself accountable to that how much that benefits students uh through the improved work with schools and divisions. So first of all, just thank you for the aspiration here. First, a clarifying question.

[03:44:38] Would any of this support plan, you know, a lot of it speaks to what we will do for the federally identified schools, which I understand the board's work has some influence over, but one could argue that the SPSF is, we might have more influence on identifying the needs intensive support schools.

[03:44:58] and um you know i know that that doesn't come with resources the way that the federally identified schools might and so i'm curious first of all any vision for how this uh strategy may or may not impact need uh needs intensive improvements no i appreciate that so i think um this framework we would want to uh think about for all of those groups in need so you can see a version of this um if you know as you think about more intensively with mou school divisions i think um you know

[03:45:33] we've uh talked about the example of the federal school improvement dollars and the csi schools right as you know a very discreet set of funding ultimately i think as you think and then you think

about um the tsi schools and those those subgroups within those schools right and sort of again thinking about that's probably less of the explicit federal funding but as we think about the you know if the majority of the students were identified with students with disabilities, then really thinking through, okay, how do we align on the back end so that the resources we're investing in,

[03:46:06] whether it's IDEA or state dollars, right, that that's aligned. As you think about the evolution of the school performance and support framework and the reason that Dr. K. White shared that kind of overarching slide is that as these as we sort of raise expectations um and what we want our students to know and be able to do and as you identify additional schools that um we would want to think about all of the needs intensive support and even if there are resources right the approaching expectations the goal would be to get everybody to meet any expectations that's a bigger

[03:46:46] lift um and i think in that case one really does have to be able to in the the term used in louisiana was the super app but like you have to be able to say what are all the resources supporting kind of flowing through the department from all the title dollars right to all the state dollars and really thinking through you know how do we get to kind of one framework one hub right sort of one application um i just you know as we were doing this work was talking with chief burda around those mou school divisions and even the resources flowing through and even at this point in time um we we

[03:47:22] don't easily have available like everything like we can tell you all about the sort of mou specific work and what's federal what's what's funded with the federal school improvement dollars but when you think about some of the other things that richmond or petersburg or franklin city have applied for like we just we have just we have operated in isolation of each other and so that is the ultimate goal but there is real structural work that goes far beyond the federal school improvement dollars to achieve that but absolutely that's the goal i love that goal and and that's reflected by the fact that you talk about divisions often as as your evidence of

[03:47:58] progress and just want to note that by my count i think there's currently 37 csi or atsi schools whereas i think there's 126 um needs intensive improvement or something like that uh number of schools in addition to those three mou divisions so first i just want to advocate for all the legislatures just uh paying attention right now uh the uh the you know with a bold plan like this i needs investment in funding and uh beyond what the federal provides so that our sbsf we've raised the standards for what we want divisions to do we need to match that with

[03:48:38] resources and support and this is the strategy to do it but i would advocate strongly that that strategy not be tied just to those 37 schools but ultimately to a broader ambition and a division wide ambition uh and then finally my my question on that would be in the application itself i know the application currently might be tied more to the 37 schools um but you'll get evidence of progress we've named as division as a key actor so is there a role for um what is the role that

[03:49:12] you'd like to see for divisions in helping direct uh what schools apply for and if there's a coordination across schools uh just because you know to try to prevent the isolated school by school efforts but the coordinated across uh division efforts absolutely so the office of school improvement, they've had office hours, they've done webinars to really support division leaders and how this could impact just not the one school, but other schools, and how to basically work their way to identify their schools the best for the funding for this type of application,

[03:49:48] since this is our first iteration of that. And so I think with that discussion, we've gotten a few questions around that, but it's really about how they know their data and how we can help them understand their data to apply to the grant and apply for the right resources that's going to actually move the needle for those students i think conversations are very important i agree with that and i think just to give a very concrete example to what dr k white is saying you know we historically have taken the school improvement dollars and divided up by the number of csi and tsi schools um and what you know ends up happening is that it becomes sort of smaller amounts of money

[03:50:27] um and it treats all those schools the same even though the context is very different so when you think about the very pronounced school-wide need for CSI schools as compared to, I think, outside of any consequence that over 80 percent of our TSI schools are otherwise distinguished or meets expectations, right? And so what you need there and what we want the system to do is say, we need you to pay equal attention and/or provide additional resources to their subgroups, but that's such a different premise than, you know, that multiple subgroups in your schools are

[03:51:02] struggling and so uh kind of what is coming out together is you know a uh for the csi schools this longer time horizon more resources per school with the idea of kind of demonstrating a strategic use so that we know that we're more likely to see a change in action and kind of outcomes we're also less likely to see what we've seen in the past when you divide the dollars up and they just get spent sort of you know more on getting spent to get spend rather than strategically with the TSI work and the implementation networks we're supporting there is doing exactly that where

[03:51:41] we're saying there is a capacity if the majority of your schools and these schools and the majority of the kids in this school are demonstrating levels of proficiency attendance and growth that you're at and you know it distinguished or meets expectation then how are we looking at the data of those kids who are not having that experience and thinking very differently and that is at the both division level mr robinson and at the really looking at the building level right because the idea being like it's you're overall performing but we got to figure out what are the supports necessary to get um to work with with every subgroup right and to address those those disparities um and you know trying to kind of push this out at the same time so it's kind of

[03:52:20] doing this it both feels like it's one voice coming from the department but as dr k white described earlier it's individualized to the need rather than what we've done before which is divide it all up distribute it and help folks spend it digesting and talking at the same time which is never a good idea thank you my colleague talked about wanting to do a standing ovation when you got the slide seven i proactively had to hold my hands in my lap because i was getting ready to

[03:52:53] do a like a you know one of those big whoop cheers um because that's the slide that represents the balance of support and accountability and as a board member who joined in march i've been awaiting the day when we started getting to the support side of that equation um eagerly and so this is really exciting to to hear about what the what the what the road ahead looks like um i have we're all this is so important because this is this is unlike the agency strategic plan

[03:53:26] an area in state code where it's a board shall that it's our job to ensure that the department and the superintendent are are effective in administering the school improvement program so i'm thinking about all that we need to do to help ensure that this is successful i think deeper understanding along the lines of what my colleague has just pointed out i would love to know it doesn't have to be right now but

what does this actually look like to a school a csi school you know from their perspective because you've done such a good job conceptualizing the division

[03:54:03] perspective but if i'm a if i'm one of those i had 33 but you said 37 um oh yes okay if i'm one of those schools you know what will the year ahead look like for me compared to our again 209 needs intensive support or 402 off track like are they going to feel or see anything different i see some conversations coming about the tsi schools and that improvement network etc so some more tangible sense again not to put you on the spot right now but just trying to get my head around what this

[03:54:39] is actually looking like as things roll out on the school level side and then i think i just want to encourage us to continue to use the language and the and the concepts that you articulate on slide six too and this is not a criticism or contradiction of what william said earlier on slide six i saw the language around you know you're really targeting to school in need of the most supports and i would be remiss if i didn't put my academic hat on and tell y'all what i always tell my

[03:55:15] students when i hear high needs students i always tell them stick an unmet in between the high and the need because i have yet to meet a child including my own that didn't have high needs it's just that we as a society do a lot better job meeting the needs of some than we do others and so this language i when you were using the in need of the most support starts to get to that sense of it's not all of our schools have um of high needs and they we should expect that they do it's just where are the ones that are getting the supports that are meeting those needs and where

[03:55:53] aren't those and you're going to start to really hone in on those that um aren't getting those supports so i really appreciate that i don't know that there was a question in there it was just thinking out loud and then asking for some more tangible examples so we understand what this will look like and feel like in the feet absolutely we can definitely provide that thank you so much no i don't have questions i have comments um i also was going to do a happy dance for the whole presentation and it's so thank you for that because i i did sit on um at least two or three

[03:56:31] of those uh and most uh the mou districts um when they were coming out and it's almost like you captured everything they said in terms of their experience in the best practices and so i just want to name a couple of them but the the first part they felt and you just codified it in paper is that they actually felt there was a partnership with um the the doe to ensure that there was a process for them to get out but what they also said is they had no clarity on what they need to do to get out yes and so this is way more clearly outlined i think it's it's a comp combination of

[03:57:11] work around the SPSF the accountability and so it is really nicely coming together um the other thing that you said and again it's what you echoed is just the duplication of effort efforts and the divisions not talking to one another it's like you're treating us like we're regular but we're not we're in a high unmet need district and so there was just confusion which meant less time in schools and class and more paperwork so i think that um it's just very very much reflective of what we heard um and the last two things i again just want to emphasize there what what i see here is

[03:57:49] just a tremendous level of transparency which is again what the divisions have asked for the one thing just to be mindful of and it's all about the capacity is that what what we heard is that not all divisions are the same and they don't need all the same so whether you're rural or urban you're small and so really just thinking through as you think through capacity how that is addressed so that everyone doesn't get the same thing when they don't they don't need it so again i'm not

[03:58:19] gonna do a happy dance but my mind yeah yeah yeah thank you board president and and i'm glad uh i think also i would like to note uh miss kilgore i think your candy uh helped create an energy and thank you for that i'm just gonna i'm gonna say i know it's correlational not not causational but i would um i think about a part of what we wanted to achieve today and i really appreciate uh president ashton's tying together what we learned through the exit interviews with the

[03:58:55] mou school divisions is that um if uh and noting uh uh dr bridges point about the kind of the board shall if the board in general was pleased with this direction is starting to think through um you know you how do we continue to move towards implementation what we've described a little bit of the work underway with the csi and the tsi schools i think mr robinson you named an important gap on needs and intensive support. And we'll go back and take a look at those. Dr. Kay Wyatt and

[03:59:29] the team and I have also talked about with this new framework in mind, it would seem kind of a very appropriate time to more deeply re-engage the MOU divisions. And I think sort of similar to what really resonated with this body, which was an idea of some form of deeper interview around what is working where there are gaps as well as sharing this framework with the leadership the division leadership and the board leadership to say this is how we're approaching this work as

[04:00:06] we go forward and to think about how would we as you just described kind of customize our approach for petersburg richmond city and franklin city and then kind of bring that back to you at the same time what helped support this presentation today was a deep dive that we did on CSI schools and so I think we could also do a data deep dive on our MOU divisions and be prepared to then kind of come back so again kind of doing that listening and building uh in pieces sort of piloting that and constantly checking with you all that to the spirit of transparency and what's working but I would would think that would be a next step for us in addition to what Deputy Superintendent

[04:00:46] high sample describe as a work in progress with csi and tsi but i think taking this combining what has worked with these exit interviews getting a little deeper on what does this mean for our mou division so that the two shells you're responsible which is ultimately the agency-wide school improvement and the work with mous that we're all on the same page on the path thank you okay thank

[04:01:09] JoAnne Hanrahan: Thank you so much Okay, we have one more item on our work session, does the board need a seven minute bio break okay great we'll come back and actually we'll take 10 minutes to 55 we'll be back.

[04:01:28] JoAnne Hanrahan: Thank you.

[04:11:26] JoAnne Hanrahan: Our last item item E the fall 2026 school performance and support framework results superintendent Conway. - Wonderful, thank you and welcome, Deputy Superintendent Hyslop.

[04:11:43] We are, as Dr. Smith started us off this morning, so very appreciative of all of the teams and staff at the Virginia Department of Education who have been working since January to make sure that we were in a place as an organization in partnership with our 131 school divisions to roll out the results for our school performance and support framework.

[04:12:10] We have briefed nearly all members of this body in advance of that rollout in early October, but wanted to today provide the opportunity to walk you through at a very high level those results, how the field has responded to the rollout.

[04:12:26] And as you just heard from Dr. K. Wyatt, where the rubber meets the road terms of resources for improvement it truly takes a partnership and so whether it is the work with this body to align on some of those changes that we needed to make for fall 26 whether it is the work with the school divisions from whom we needed that data by the end of august in order to crunch numbers and put out these results or whether it is the technology the communications the policy the instruction the school improvement and the accountability and assessment teams at the vdoe

[04:13:06] who've come together to execute on a project plan to to deliver these um and so just great appreciation i will also note that the week after the school performance and support framework results rolled out we also rolled out uh just under 3 200 bqb5 quality profiles and so there'll will be more to come, I believe, at the December award meeting with the kind of high-level results there. But, you know, understanding, you know, kind of how our schools and students are doing

[04:13:41] is essential to supporting improvement. I'll also note, and Deputy Superintendent Heisselt will end with this, like any good implementation, you learn as you go. And so, we came to this body, led by deputy superintendent high slope in august to say here is the road map for the next few years and to the spirit of your comment earlier um and then changes tomorrow um that we are going to end with not asking for decisions from this body today or tomorrow but to highlight for you three

[04:14:14] things that uh this year's process has um uh led us to realize that we need kind of three changes for fall of 2027. And at some point in the upcoming months, we'll bring those three decisions to this group. But so kind of planning, you know, doing, learning as you do, and then continually iterating is always the spirit of our work. And with that, I'll turn it to Deputy Superintendent Hyslop. Thank you, Superintendent Conway. Thank you, President Ashton, Vice President Bridges, and members of the board. Happy to be here. I know we have spent a lot of today

[04:14:52] talking about our strategic plan, where we want to be in 2030, sort of hopes for the future. And I am also thinking about fall 2027 SPSF results and fall 2028 and fall 2029. But today is really reflecting on fall 2026 and the results we just released. And I can do this in the dark if need be at this point. I feel like I've looked and analyzed at this data so much, but we really did make a lot of, I think, strategic decisions about how we could make the fall 2026 rollout of this

[04:15:29] critical piece of information learned from last year and continue to improve as we move forward. So while there's definitely, I think, a lot of themes and consistency with some of the presentations you heard from Secretary Smith, from Chief Coy, from Dr. K. Wyatt about sort of our long-term strategic plan goals, this is really a moment for all of us to sort of reflect on where we are right now and the things we are doing in this moment to not just sort of say look we put out a great website and all these great results but how we are using them to drive meaningful change for our students. So as I present a sort of agenda here I think as I always do trying to

[04:16:09] start with why this even matters then I highlight some of the things that we saw from the fall 2026 release and that is not just SPSS but it is also our school accreditation results that were released and then ending with sort of that what we are doing right now in fall 2026 with supports for improvement particularly for schools that are federally identified so you know measurement ultimately is our tool that we have one of the strongest tools we have at the VDOE for supporting students by informing assisting and motivating educators leaders and families so the adults

[04:16:42] who are supporting our students and you know we have said time and time again ad nauseum that we know our students are as capable and we need as anyone else in the country they have high aspirations we need a measurement system um and that includes our assessment and accountability that support that support those student aspirations by informing us as those who are leading these systems who are teaching our students to know you know where where we need to take action to support them to meet our high expectations for them but also to be able to celebrate their success because we certainly saw a lot of that with these results both things that we need to focus on for the

[04:17:21] future but also things that we're really proud of and yeah i think that you have seen this slide already today too as well but this is situated within a broader system um for how we are going to be thinking about driving improved student outcomes so it's not just the school performance and support framework it is also our state assessment systems but that is measuring our standards of learning which this body has taken so much time over the last several years to really raise the bar for what we are holding our students to what they need to know and learn in key subjects and then all of that feeds into what you just heard from Dr. K Wyatt our support

[04:17:58] and resources how are we using all of this information to prioritize those students who have the greatest needs who need have the greatest need of support and how are we prioritizing those and changing our behavior whether that's through funding whether that's through how we spend our time as a state agency, where we go, where we send our teams in response to that. So when every piece is working together, you know, we do think that that was going to be a key lever to driving improved student outcomes and meeting some of those strategic plan goals that Chief Coy and Ms. Eppel

[04:18:32] laid out. So now shifting to really what did we see from our data release highlights on earlier in October? And I think truly it was a ton of progress that we wanted to celebrate, but also not just progress in terms of student and school outcomes, but also progress for our own processes, you know, really trying to get clearer about communications. This is still a new system to many. They may not have heard of the SPSF before, and really trying to lay the groundwork and create those conditions for meaningful school improvement. So this slide just shows a handful of some of the headlines that

[04:19:09] we got coming out of the October 7th release. That day, like I mentioned, we didn't just release school performance and support framework results for all um 1810 school 12 schools in the commonwealth but we also released accreditation designations we released a lot of data like chronic absenteeism graduation rates um advanced coursework information so it was a big data release even if spsf got a lot of the attention um we saw you know just continued progress across the board really on all these metrics for the most part more schools be rated distinguished more schools are fully

[04:19:44] accredited more schools were able to exit from the most serious federal improvement designation comprehensive support and improvement and and we also were able to announce sort of 26 million dollars in federal grant funding almost immediately and make that available for divisions to apply for meaningful awards to support their students and schools with the greatest needs um so I think that was you know we tried to do this deliberately having that that was one thing we had heard from last year was that this there was too much of a delay between when the results

[04:20:20] came out and when some of the supports were available so we tried to have that be pretty much instantaneous this year as I mentioned we also really tried to focus on how we could be a partner to divisions and schools and other stakeholders in this process and have a more collaborative release

learning from a lot of the feedback we got last year what we heard on commonwealth listening tour and what we have heard since over the summer so we took a lot of sort of extra steps in the process to be sure that we were sharing the accreditation and spsf data

[04:20:54] directly with divisions prior to the probably so they got previews of their accreditation results of their spsf results of the school ratings we could answer questions that they had um in some cases you know they would point out errors and we would correct the data you know things it just made it so that they were not surprised by what they saw on october 7th we also really worked to develop a communications toolkit for divisions knowing that this is a new system so are there tools that we could give them to help them be ambassadors for this data in their

[04:21:28] own communities whether that's talking points shell powerpoint presentations social media graphics that they could borrow and adapt for their own use. And we really worked to have materials as well that highlighted each of the eight superintendents' regions. That was something that was done last year as well. There were these regional snapshots, but we got a lot of positive feedback on those. And so we tried to continue and improve them for this year. We also held multiple briefings ahead of time with local superintendents, with state leaders like yourself, with division special education leaders.

[04:22:03] And that was adapted over time as we saw, for example, that we were gonna have a lot more targeted support and improvement schools for students with disabilities in particular. We added that webinar for special education leaders. So we also tried to modify and make changes to our sort of rollout plan based on the data in real time.

[04:22:22] We added extra webinars for some of our division leaders when we like, oh, here was a surprising thing folks might not have been expecting to see in the data let's be sure that we're communicating that proactively with them so we did try to really partner with them and i think this is something that we felt was successful but obviously there's always room for improvement and that we're going to build on for next year as well we also were fortunate to be able to do two really wonderful school visits with two schools one in henrico county glenley elementary school which is a csi school comprehensive support and improvement but had some of the largest gains from fall 2025 to

[04:23:02] fall 2026 the governor joined us for that visit as long along with secretary smith and you know for example uh their score last year was 61.55 points they were nearly 77 this year this is a title one csi school that is now fully accredited they were not fully accredited last year and so that was a big deal for them and we were fortunate to be able to celebrate that progress with them

[04:23:27] We also visited Armstrong High School here in Richmond. They were a school that exited CSI, Comprehensive Support and Improvement, and did not enter Targeted Support and Improvement. So they were among the bottom 5% for all students, and now they don't even have an individual group of students that meets that bar.

[04:23:46] So they were another school that we really wanted to highlight, and that was a visit that we did as a VDOE team that I think was just really meaningful to be with the educators, with the teachers, with the school leaders that made that possible. but diving now a little bit into the results themselves and what we saw and many of you got this information before the release so this should be somewhat familiar starting with school accreditation this year the headline is that we have 99.7 percent of virginia schools fully accredited that is up from 96.8 last year and just as a refresher accreditation largely looks at

[04:24:25] issues of compliance so things like graduation requirements your leadership and staffing facilities and school safety but it does also look at student outcomes particularly for our federally identified schools in comprehensive support and improvement so while accreditation and accountability are largely separated they're not fully separated as a result of accreditation schools get one of three designations fully accredited meaning that they've submitted all the required evidence that they're in compliance with these policies and that evidence is deemed satisfactory those schools are fully accredited conditionally accredited schools are those that

[04:25:02] have not submitted fully satisfactory evidence and so it's either something is non-compliant with one of their policies or potentially they're a csi school that has not demonstrated sufficient progress academically and then the final designation is accreditation denied we do not have any schools currently that are accreditation denied all schools in virginia either conditionally accredited or fully accredited to dive a little bit more specifically into those numbers so of that 99.7 that represents 50 of the superintendent's regions so all schools

[04:25:38] in regions four five seven and eight are fully accredited that includes northern virginia sort of the blue ridge and valley area southwest virginia and south side so 100 of schools in those four regions are fully accredited 100 of schools in virginia especially once we allow divisions to submit further evidence they actually met all of those policy requirements the 0.3 or six csi schools that are conditionally accredited are there because they did not demonstrate sufficient academic progress um and growth and so that is if you're what we if you're understanding how could

[04:26:18] So we say it's 99.7%, but then 100%, it's because 100% were fully compliant with those policies. The schools that are conditionally accredited are there because they were CSI schools where we examined their academic growth and progress. And it was insufficient to show that they were making sufficient progress to exit.

[04:26:38] And then that had not been sustained. Some of them may have had one year of progress, but it wasn't sustained progress. That is our accreditation results. Turning to our fall 2026 school performance support framework results, we also saw tremendous progress. 38% of schools improved their overall performance category or rating from last year. Again, 99% of schools are fully accredited.

[04:27:04] And with that 38% improving the rating, also, we looked at just the number of points, the scores that schools got. And overall, those scores increased by roughly five points on average. And that was especially driven upon progress for our elementary schools. And part of that, you recall one of the things that did change from fall 2025 to fall 2026 was how we measure growth in elementary and middle schools that you know there weren't a ton of policy changes between last year's spsf and this year's but that was one of them and it does seem to based on our initial analysis bearing in the sum of the progress that we saw especially in the elementary grades

[04:27:42] we also saw that 75 percent three out of four schools in virginia improved their chronic absenteeism rates which is part of readiness for all schools in virginia that is one of the indicators you know readiness has many different measures but chronic absenteeism is always a measure in the readiness component another um piece that i think is you know very much worth shouting out and part of the reason why we went to armstrong high school is that we saw tremendous progress amongst our lowest performing title one schools we had the highest number of schools ever exit csi status in a single year 16 schools armstrong was one of them um and that's you know

[04:28:22] i think a point that you think about those lowest performing five percent of title one schools these are are some of our students who have the greatest needs um and we'll touch on that a little bit later some more details about those schools but that's a progress point that we're we are really excited to see and one of the reasons why we wanted to highlight armstrong so diving in a little bit to those spsf overall scores increasing here you can just see the breakdown by elementary middle schools high schools and then all schools in the spsf so typically we saw an increase of roughly four to five points overall so that translates as you can see here to the average

[04:28:58] score for a high school being 94 points average scores overall for all schools 89 points um and then here you again see like the elementary schools in particular had significant fall to um fall 25 to fall 2026 improvement but we did see that improvement in high schools as well even if it was a slightly smaller gain. Thinking about the school ratings and how those scores translate into a performance category, here you can see it's sort of the distribution of the ratings from fall

[04:29:32] 2025 to fall 2026. Note here, this is probably the other big change between fall 2025 and fall 2026 is that we, as the board voted on over the summer, to update the school performance category names so our on-track label became meets expectations our off-track label became approaching expectations we didn't change the number of points associated with those two labels but the the label category name itself changed so generally speaking here you can see more schools are earning distinguished uh performance categories than last year and we have fewer

[04:30:08] that are in that needs intensive support uh than before the approaching or off-track stayed roughly similar so in many ways if you're just looking at the total distribution there's a little bit of a flip-flop between distinguished and meets expectations are on track at the total level but there's some different points you can look at for the different grade bands which i think is helpful just to look through there and this is one thing that you know we really wanted to double down double click on here is just there is differences still in the distribution of those performance categories by grade band this is something that jlark pointed out last year

[04:30:47] where they noted that, you know, high schools were far more likely to be distinguished. We've closed some of that gap this year. There are now elementary and middle schools, more of a larger share of them that are getting that distinguished rating. However, high schools are still disproportionately, the percentages are not quite similar across the three grade levels. And this is part of our work plan for moving forward. Obviously, you know, we've talked about this and sort of have laid out when we might be able to reconsider some of those point thresholds, because right now we are using the same SPSF point threshold for all of the performance categories.

[04:31:25] So that is something that we will be addressing and it's just not something that we did for this fall. Here, as I mentioned, we saw a lot of improvement in chronic absenteeism. One piece that's helpful to see with this slide is that we still are not where we were prior to the pandemic.

[04:31:44] So while we are pleased to see that three out of four schools are improving their rates of chronic absenteeism, we still have a way to go to get back to where we were. And that is for all grade bands. It's not uncommon to see the highest rates of chronic absenteeism among high school students.

[04:32:00] That's typical nationally, but that's probably where we have the furthest to go there. But even with elementary schools, we were at 8.8% chronic absenteeism before COVID. Last year it was 9.9. So another place that we wanna continue making progress moving forward.

[04:32:18] The next several slides really get into more on the federal identification slide. So as I mentioned, we did see the largest number of schools ever since the Every Student Succeeds Act was in existence, exit in a single year. That ended up being 16 out of 49 eligible schools.

[04:32:37] So not all of our CSI schools were eligible to exit. Schools that were identified for CSI for the first time last year were not eligible. So that 49 represents our CSI schools had been in csi before last fall and so if you're wondering it was total last year we had 79 csi schools and 16 of the 79 exited one of those 79 schools closed so we currently have 62 csi schools

[04:33:09] in virginia um but of this of the 16 i think one of the things like like armstrong they were not the only school that completely exited federal identification status so they went from csi and then they're not identified for tsi 10 of those 16 schools were identified for tsi and that means that their overall performance category was lowered by one and this is some of the feedback that we got from those school leaders where they said this seems like we're being punished for doing better you know it feels like we've made all this tremendous work to exit csi and now we're in

[04:33:47] tsi and our category is being lowered so that is i think as uh superintendent conway was alluding to one of the things that we are working to address for next fall and this board did open the notice of intent to initiate a regulatory action to address that last month so that is one of the things that we are looking to you know reconsider come present some options to this board about how we might have TSI status affect a school's rating moving forward. But for these 16, 10 of them did ultimately end up in targeted support and improvement. I think it's also notable that 13

[04:34:23] of these were among the lowest performing 5% of Title I schools for all students. The other three schools had originally started out in additional targeted support and improvement for a particular group of students. And then because they didn't improve from ATSI, they became csi so most of these schools were among the lowest performing five percent for all students there were a few that were identified for particular student groups and all 13 of those had been um those 13 that were among the lowest performing for all kids had been identified since the 2018 school year the first time so i think this is really showing the arc of a lot of work

[04:35:03] among those schools um and also a shout out to region seven they no longer have any csi schools and waynesboro pulaski county and prince edward county exited their only csi school and those were some of the csi schools that the team visited on the back to school tour so prince edward middle for example and kritzer elementary in pulaski county but this is the federal identification picture when you think about fewer csi schools now so we have that decrease in large part because of

[04:35:37] those 16 that exited and we did not identify any new csi schools this fall so schools exited but but we did not do a new identification because we only identify CSI schools once every three years. And we did that last year. So this was not a CSI identification year.

[04:35:54] And you can see here, most of those are elementary schools, but we do have CSI middle schools, high schools, and some schools that are combined grade bands. I think the single biggest sort of, one of the bigger headlines here is actually, we do have many more TSI schools.

[04:36:11] And sort of unpacking the why here is one of the things we spent a lot of time in our communications plan trying to explain and in some ways it's good news bad news because the good news here is our title our lowest performing title one schools did a lot better and because they did better that

raised the bar for when we came to look at individual student group performance the bar was higher this year than it was last year um so we went from having 430 total targeted support and improvement schools last year to 674 um actually federally

[04:36:45] identified schools went from 430 to 674 it is 607 targeted support schools so we have those 62 schools that are in CSI we have five schools that remain in additional targeted support and improvement we aren't talking much about ATSI schools in this slide because there are only five of them we have not yet identified ATSI schools under the new school performance and support framework those are sort of legacy schools that are still in ATSI from the prior system um but in particular you know the vast vast majority of our 674 federally identified

[04:37:19] schools are in TSI and we saw increases at all school levels so the number of TSI elementary schools increased by 100 schools we went from 13 to 77 TSI middle schools and we did not have any TSI high schools last year and this year there are 98 of them so we saw this increase across the the board. And again, it is because the bar, the threshold that we use for determining if a student group is underperforming is based on how our lowest performing Title I schools are doing.

[04:37:54] Those schools did better. And as a result, the threshold got higher. So if you're wondering what that looks like here, these are the actual thresholds. So you can see in particular that the teal line shows the TSI thresholds that were used this year, the gray bar, the gray line is from last year. And we look at not just overall SPSF scores, we also look at reading, math and science performance. So there are four metrics that we look at for students, individual student group at a school, and we compare it. And if the student group is below that mark in all four,

[04:38:33] the school is a TSI school. One of the four is not enough, two of the four is not enough, has to be all of them but even so we do see that because our title one schools did so well the bar was raised for everyone especially for our high schools and that meant that that comparison point was more rigorous and so we have 607 schools that are in targeted support and improvement this year most of those the vast majority were identified for students with disabilities you can be in targeted support and improvement for multiple groups and we do have schools like that but the vast majority you know over it's 84 just for students with disabilities so i think that is one

[04:39:13] of those reasons why we then said we need to think about how we partner with our division special education directors how we partner with the office of special populations and thinking about how we support these schools in particular you know knowing that the whole purpose of tsi identification is to make sure that we are responding appropriately with the supports and the resources to help our divisions build capacity to support those students so we are really working both to think about what do we do to support our remaining CSI and ACSI schools but also this group of

[04:39:48] schools and just as a quick recap on federal identification we are required by federal law that our federal identification is part of our overall framework for identifying schools but currently we have that federal identification impact a school's SPSF results in different ways so even though TSI is the sort of lightest level of support that is needed in some ways like significant very significant consequence is applied to those schools by lowering their performance category by one so TSI schools cannot be distinguished but it meets expectations TSI

[04:40:28] school becomes approaching expectations. And approaching expectations, TSI school becomes needs intensive support because of that TSI identification. The same thing is true for our additional

targeted support and improvement schools. They would have the same consequence applied to them. There are just far fewer of them. So I think when we were hearing from school divisions, it was by and large about their TSI schools because there are only five ATSI schools currently in the Commonwealth. So even though our comprehensive support schools, that is our most intensive support needed those are our bottom five percent of title one schools for all students

[04:41:04] or all students have graduation rates below 67 percent um they just can't receive a distinguished rating so that is currently what our policies are and this is one reason why um one thing something we talked about last month when we brought forward that nora was you know how we could address some of these inconsistencies moving forward and it is definitely a top concern that we heard from school pool division leaders as these results came out. So we are working as expeditiously as possible to address that for next fall. Because, you know, I think, as we said, it was very heartbreaking to talk to some of those, particularly those CSI schools that exited and then felt like they were

[04:41:42] being punished for doing so. And they felt like, you know, are we, did we get that balance right here of CSI feels like it should be the more intensive consequence, yet it feels like that's actually the reverse that we're doing that for our TSI schools but not our CSI. So shifting a little bit more to many of the themes that we just heard from Dr. K. Wyatt about the really exciting work that we are doing to drive supports and resources to our schools that have been federally identified.

[04:42:14] So probably this we have sort of three key strategies that we are working to implement and they sort of are aligned with the different tiers of support that have been identified from the SPSF. So the first of these is thinking about how do we spend our federal school improvement grant dollars. This is a set aside from Title I. It has to be spent in school divisions with federally identified schools, and we have roughly over $26 million that were available. So we have consolidated two years of funding, that's how we got to the $26 million, into a single more

[04:42:50] streamlined grant application, and we are prioritizing, and I'll talk a little bit about the way that we have changed and modified that application to try and really link it to our strategic plan and our instructional priorities and vision for how we implement HQIM in all classrooms in Virginia. In response to sort of the larger number of TSI schools, we also are working to develop and pilot a new network for school and division leaders for our TSI schools to sort of help build their capacity locally. It's not a direct grant opportunity, but it's still a new network to support them. And then we are going to continue

[04:43:27] and increase and double down on the support for our educators serving students with disabilities in all of our schools. And we already have a number of very successful collaboratives and initiatives, whether that's the regional T-TACS, the Virginia Tier System of support. So just being sure that we are really thinking, again, as an agency, about how we leverage all parts of the agency towards supporting these schools and knowing that the Office of Special Populations under Dr. Hollins, or Dr. I may have just made Sam a doctor, and Deputy

[04:44:00] Superintendent Hollins, is also part of a key partner in this work. So really focusing now on that federal school improvement grant. So we released the application on October 9th for these funds. The schools that are eligible initially are those that are in CSI and ATSI. So those 67 schools, they are in 25 school divisions because they have the greatest and most persistent needs.

[04:44:28] In response to sort of the feedback that we got last year, it was important for us to make these awards more timely, so to not have the awards come months after the identification results were released

but we also wanted to be sure that they were of a meaningful size and really targeted toward core instructional priorities so we made a shift this year to make this a competitive grant as opposed to more of a formula grant so the priorities for this grant are twofold one is showing the strongest commitment to implementing high quality instructional materials as the

[04:45:04] foundation of tier one instruction for all students so really looking at how they are implementing our standards, our HQIM, in both reading and math, and providing them support to do so. The second is having the greatest need for funds. And the way that we're measuring need is, for example, divisions that have multiple schools as opposed to just one. Divisions that may be in more rural areas or remote areas are prioritized under greatest need. Divisions that are sort of a CSI school that's been in CSI for a very long time. These are ways that we are thinking about need.

[04:45:41] The minimum grant award is $100,000 per school. The maximum is $500,000 per school. This is significantly higher than in past years, in part because we want to be sure that the activities that are funded by this really are going to help our school divisions build their capacity, bring in an external partner, and a grant of $75,000 simply does not enable you to do that.

[04:46:03] So we really try to be very intentional here about prioritizing meaningful school improvement aligned with our strategic plan, especially around instruction and HQIM. And the Office of School Improvement has been working hand-in-hand with the Office of Instruction in designing this grant to be sure, again, you're sort of agency-wide school improvement. This is not just owned by one team, but we are working across our finance teams with Chief Berta, with Deputy Superintendent Prophet to be sure that we are aligned fully around that instructional vision. We will have

[04:46:36] our applications due at the end of this month. So on Friday, we are intending to award these grants prior to winter break so that our school divisions can get to work. And if we do have leftover funds, we will then think about expanding to maybe have TSI schools that are in needs intensive support apply for funding. But we wanted to first prioritize this $26 million opportunity to those divisions that have the schools that have the most persistent um and most uh challenging needs and then we'll go from there but i think this also will enable us to again get those awards

[04:47:12] out very quickly we didn't want to have a process that took so long that we basically didn't get grants out until the spring and then the school year is almost over um so we very much prioritize that. Secondly, mentioned the new school improvement network. So we are going to be working with and also again in partnership with the Office of Instruction and the instructional team about thinking about how we could bring TSI schools leaders and division leaders together because they likely have many similar challenges. You know they have their unique challenges but many of them

[04:47:51] are identified for students with disabilities. So thinking about how we can help them build their capacity to better understand the conditions that are contributing to achievement gaps through instruction helping them understand how they can implement hqm with fidelity and build sort of again tier one instruction and hqm is the core of their work um this opportunity is one that we are actively we are working on now i think just talking to the team i think a notice will be coming out to division soon about how they can apply it's going to be voluntary opt-in we're not requiring anyone to do this but we think it will be a really meaningful opportunity for divisions to learn from

[04:48:29] one another and to build sort of that peer-to-peer learning for those TSI schools that you know are not the highest need in many cases these are some schools that are distinguished or meets

expectations but do have an individual group of students that is struggling and how can they learn from one another learn from our team learn from experts that we bring in um to think about are you implementing hqim in all of your classrooms you know not not just in some but in all are have you adopted those materials are you using them consistently and giving them tools both to help track some of that but some data tools to sort of be monitoring walk through tools of classrooms and really

[04:49:07] walking alongside those division and school leaders to help them use those tools more effectively and as i mentioned we may depending on how this first round of sig funding goes we may be able to fund some TSI schools, depending on whether there are funds available. And then finally, for our students with disabilities, this slide here just highlights some of the ongoing supports and resources that we are going to be sure are really intentionally focused for TSI schools.

[04:49:37] Obviously, all schools across the Commonwealth can benefit from the regional T-TACs, from our tiered systems of support, from the RIC at VCU and other university partners, but making that connection explicitly to targeted support improvement and school improvement um and being sure that we are supporting our school leaders and families of students with disabilities in particular to be part of this effort um so while it may not be something new i think it's doing this with intentionality and with school improvement in mind um and really trying to build those connections

[04:50:12] between my team the office of um the office of school improvement but also our instruction and special populations teams as well in the office of special education happy to pivot to questions and or comments sure they'll be both superintendent wonderful thank you and and i hope you saw in this presentation in addition to a very thorough overview of the data some of uh what is described is is in line with that framework presented by by melanie when you think about kind of you

[04:50:51] ensuring that we had one application going out in a timely fashion that reflected the input from special populations instruction federal program school improvement and accountability um thinking about um they're doing work behind the scenes to think about the school improvement dollars as well as a another federal literacy grant right and really thinking through sort of the highest and best use for the value add of these dollars um and uh and then kind of you know a sort of a delineated approach when it is a whole school in need versus a um a particular subgroup within a

[04:51:30] school but this uh hopefully is kind of a a model of this but really sort of coming with speaking with one voice simplified application process to the questions raised by mr robinson earlier thinking about kind of the metrics already we've sort of thought like we were a letter came from me that went directly to csi uh division leads right rather than the school's division lead saying hey this is an you know as an agency we are making sure that you're aware of this this funding application as an agency we stand ready to support you uh to apply um and then i think the other

[04:52:07] piece is just you know being very prepared to be responsive and iterative i i think you know when we look at how we identify tsi and how we assign consequences i think there was a surprise here one that again as i just noted very transparently we did not see coming when we thought you know we knew that we needed to address the consequences because jlark had had flagged that um in their in their report last year and that was one of the recommendations coming from the general assembly

[04:52:37] What we didn't foresee was that such improvement within, you know, particularly when you have a one-year average that's used to sort of set that threshold as compared to a multi-year average, that that improvement then kind of set off, you know, another set of unanticipated consequences.

[04:52:57] And so as we go, it's sort of both kind of operating against that plan, but also demonstrating flexibility when the data suggests we need to take a different approach.

[04:53:07] I think just a comment in connecting the governor's priorities and Secretary Smith's presentation, you know, there's kind of a domino effect to this. The more that we focus on the wraparound services, physical, the mental, all of those supports and making sure that our students get what they need, then, you know, as I was thinking about the chronic absenteeism slide, the more likely kids are to be present, which means they're missing less instruction and you know like we'll see the domino and the data move in the right direction so i

[04:53:45] think we're focusing on the right strategies um and looking forward to seeing the continual improvement thank you mr robinson first of all thank you for uh jumping right into a couple of the csi schools that uh exited and celebrating them as a team um and just this thoughtful uh presentation and see strong alignment with uh the past presentation that you're thinking about consolidating the funds for more strategic use that's more likely to impact division school

[04:54:22] practice and student learning and opportunities so just excellent attention to this on a short timeline and thank you for getting it out to division so quick to get them that that funding so they can use it more thoughtfully for students um my uh first of all i just want to name i think we're seeing a lot of um on the positive side evidence that the metrics and the accountability of SPSF may be driving behavior um you know this is the was the first year that uh there was a

[04:54:57] meaningful consequence of rating on chronic absenteeism and you saw rises across the commonwealth there uh increased attention to CSI schools you saw a tremendous improvement across the board so as i talked to region 5 leaders you know i was very impressed with how much they were paying attention to the the um the scores and what that means for their students not in a compliance standpoint but in terms of where we need to pay greater attention i think that uh raises the bar for this board on how we ensure that the metrics that they're paying attention to are meaningful

[04:55:35] and matter for students um and so towards that end first on the on the i want to echo and appreciate the desire to bring to us different um options for the tsi thresholds as i i do think that that had a lot of unintended consequences uh at the same time i want to name um a desire to not pivot the completely other direction. Because the intention of that was to bring attention to our most

[04:56:09] underserved learners that may not be at our most underserved schools. And, you know, so I can imagine various solutions like certain just lifted up, possibly a multi-year average or other things that make that less likely. But still, we might consider multi-year KSI schools going down in performance, but then coupling that with access to grant or support opportunities. I know that's for a later date, just want to name that. The other thing I'll name in terms of back to the metrics driving behavior, it's just how, even though I celebrate the efforts across the

[04:56:48] Commonwealth to improve performance for CSI schools, improve 3E metrics, and improve chronic absenteeism, the improvement in the overall framework compared to the improvement proficiency is way off. So we saw, I forgot what it was, 38% improve at least one performance category in a year that we saw a 1% rise in math and a 1% rise in literacy. We saw the number of schools that are distinguished versus needs-intensive improvement go from 2 to 1, 23% to 6 to 1.

[04:57:24] We have 6X more schools indistinguished and needs intensive improvement. To me, that is an indicator of an SPSF framework that is new and it makes sense that this could be unintended consequences, but where we as a board need to keep raising the bar. So as we think about the growth scores and indicators and tables, I hope we consider ways of doing that that reflect the raised bar that our educators pertaining will rise to when we're clear on that because a doubling of distinguished goals and increase at 38 percent in categories in a year that we only increase achievement by one

[04:58:03] percent seems off. Thank you, Mr. Robinson. I think and agree with you on all of those points. I think thinking about federal identification, how you do it and what consequences you attach, I know it's something that we as a team have discussed on the one hand um you know there is an importance in getting uh systems system leaders and building leaders to pay attention to uh students furthest

[04:58:38] from opportunity um two of my three children attend a school that went from being csi to tsi and on the side of a soccer field had a conversation about the implications and you know he he said well i know exactly what kids were talking about and we already got a plan in place and so it was a just a reminder on the power of of these systems to help drive additional attention and then you know aligned resources that with us sort of you know hoping and supporting the the latter as being really key and as we think through that decision in front of that body that

[04:59:13] will be that will be so important i think you as we think about the other two things so if the the federal identification and the consequences are one item that we think needs to be addressed before fall for the fall 2027 results i think the other two have to do with uh what you've raised and i would sort of raise it at a at a slightly broader level which is you had you know some pretty significant improvement you know that is maybe not uh completely in sync with what you saw in terms of overall performance and you now you are uh mid-year in the implementation of higher expectations

[04:59:50] and there's a little bit of risk with this that you are starting to create i'll use what the board president used a whiplash right and so you went from here to here and then you know sort of there kind of based on very preliminary math in the current system my experience in 15 years of doing accountability systems across two states is that that much movement regardless of positive or negative you can seriously erode credibility in the system and none of it is intentional this is not you know whether it's sort of my predecessors or us here right i'm not you know we could run the

[05:00:27] math exactly as was as is today and could result with a backlash you know or sort of a whiplash excuse me situation that would make it harder for leaders educators community stakeholders others to trust and so as we think about um what will be in front of this body if these are in general as j lark said directionally the right things to be measuring proficiency growth absenteeism access to advanced coursework employment enrollment enlistment but we've got to make some adjustments to kind of the methodology around how we calculate that

[05:01:06] in order to smooth some of that is what will be in front of it. I think specifically looking at this body has to vote on a growth table for fall of 2027. And when you do that, because some of this year's increase was related to growth table changes, might this body also want to look at the mastery index and think through as you have these higher expectations, You know, would you want to make a set of shifts that sort of both reflect what was learned about federal identification and consequences, but also accounts for what we learned from the past two years and accounts for what is in front of us in terms of raising expectations.

[05:01:44] And so those are the three areas, federal identification and consequences, growth, and the Mastery Index that we foresee in our starting work on, really started on work on October 8th, I would say, immediately following rollout, we give them a day off.

[05:02:02] But immediately have begun work on as a team, in addition to debriefing the process, be able to come back to this body and make those changes. you've heard and for all of those listening at home I'm sure there's like six of them but talked to 14 14 you know this is not ideal I just want to acknowledge right the ideal way to do accountability system is in advance of the of the school year to say to the adults here is what we expect right so the adults organize their activities to deliver on on behalf of kids however as we said to you in August if there are things where we think that a mid-year

[05:02:39] change is needed right whether that's to sort of you know support the betterment of the system and kids that we will bring that to you and we foresee that those are three things that we need to bring to you and we'll do this in partnership with school divisions and we've had some conversations already with the associations and the superintendents and other of the education associations about that that we foresee needing to bring to you mid-year changes because that will be that will help make adults and kids better off, particularly for our students and ultimately what this system can do for students and for outcomes, you know, in, you know, over the course

[05:03:16] of the next three to four months. And if I can, those may not be the only three things. To that point, you know, there might be some more things, but I think we'll also be trying to work with this board too on changes that we are not making mid-year that are actually changes that we're hoping to make in that would take effect in fall 2028 or fall 2029 because we know this is a longer work plan and so there are also decisions that we'll work with this board to make and present different options ideas around things where we're not necessarily implementing a change six months before it takes effect but something where we are going through that process of you know let's take

[05:03:53] time let's talk to stakeholders and then let's have you know maybe a longer runway to actually implement it on the back end. But these three areas that Superintendent Conway identified are just those from based on what we saw this year, what we know about, you know, the cut scores changing and the increased expectations are changes that we have to bring forward with more immediacy. Just a quick follow-up. I love all of the thoughtfulness there again and the support to the divisions I heard about from communications that we've saw reflected in some of these articles.

[05:04:29] It is a very complicated time, and I do think we're going to continue to be in a non-ideal period for multiple years with, given all the shifts with cut scores and everything and the complexity as well as potentially the volatility. I just think we'll get more grace from divisions, not only with that type of communication support, but also if we're making shifts with urgency that just make intuitive sense to them.

[05:04:51] And that's why, you know, I know this is for another day, but it's why things like the master index on the 100 and the weighting of the growth scores closer to a one-to-one with efficiency is something that I'd advocate for more urgency, even if that means more volatility and less planning, because I think you'll get that gray thing.

[05:05:11] It would just make more intuitive sense to educators. Dr. Bridges? Yes. Thank you so much. Ms. Hyslip for this great information. Just want to say, in case folks don't realize what a state agency can do to release a grant opportunity on the 9th and have applications due on the 30th, I cannot conceive of the

work that was involved. And to communicate that in a way that you're able to get back, I mean, that's just an incredible turnaround. So, very impressive.

[05:05:48] We're also very appreciative to the divisions that are doing the work. Right. Or have submitted as of yesterday. the question part of that you know we spend a lot of time thinking about capacity that today do you think the divisions have the capacity to do that kind of turnaround on their end i think they do i think one of the things that helps in this case and we did think deliberately about that knowing it was a short timeline yeah none of these schools were newly identified all of them have multi-year school support plans already in existence they should already be implementing high quality instructional materials they should already have adopted those i think there's just

[05:06:25] something here where we weren't starting from scratch we also made deliberate choices in the design of the application to streamline it to take out questions that were not necessary to you know where to be thinking about we have these key priorities and that we need information to be able to score that priority do we need this other information and thinking very thoughtfully about that streamlining the budget workbook so rather than having a detailed budget workbook being submitted a school division doesn't know how much money they're going to get in a competitive grant so have them do a more streamlined budget and then we can get that detailed budget workbook on the back end so we did things like that there's one application per division so even if you are

[05:07:04] a division that has six csi or atsi schools it's one application on behalf of all of them so trying to be really thoughtful about just taking that application and narrowing the scope as much as we could to enable the faster turnaround again impressive that i just so appreciate uh you know improvement science cause of doing work with the end user in mind and it seems like that's becoming embedded in videoe's dna so i really appreciate that my question about that is that

[05:07:37] you know the alignment with hqim and tier one instruction um practices is there a theory in there that that that's the commonality between between those 64 schools or are we possibly missing some other challenges that they're experiencing in in that i love this question because i had this question with my team oh we talked about it because the application does allow for divisions to talk about other strategies that they're implementing so say you're a low graduation rate high school yeah and you are having a big challenge with student engagement

[05:08:15] you can have a strategy you can use funds okay that's in your plan you know to support that but the way that we are scoring the application the way that we are determining sort of those that are the strongest applications is in large part based on their commitment to implementation of HQIM as the foundation of tier one instruction because I think you know as I think about my former boss Secretary Smith like teaching and learning is the thing and you know I can't imagine a CSI school or an ATSI school that is going to be able to make the improvements needed to exit without thinking about teaching and learning and implement whether you're an elementary school most of these are

[05:08:54] elementary schools implementation of the vla like that's a big bet that our state has made so let's be sure that we're sending coherent aligned signals across the board around the importance of implementation of those high quality instruction materials in math in literacy and then actually helping teachers use those materials and know those materials it's not enough just to adopt it it's actually to giving them the support to partner with somebody to train and like do those walk through so that school leaders whether you're an assistant principal or an instructional leader is

[05:09:28] going into classrooms and seeing evidence that the chosen materials are actually being implemented and then you know providing feedback and support and like that continuous feedback loop and it just felt like as we are going through our strategic planning process as we are like looking like there's no way the construction is not like that makes sense to be the big bet here without precluding grant funds from being used to support other things if this is a school that you say has a highly mobile population or has an influx of a new student population there's that's still an

[05:10:02] allowable use of the funds it's just not how we're scoring the application if that makes sense it's a distinction here it's like what can you use money for versus how are we going what information did we want to get on the front end in terms of encouraging this focus on hqim yeah and i would actually part of what framed this was as we did a deep dive on CSI schools and again kind of you know looking at the populations looking at the communities in which they were located looking at you know certain factors right you know even for example surprising insights so the actual dollars

[05:10:42] per student at CSI schools was significantly higher than kind of we looked at both sort of what the statewide average is but then sort of similarly situated in terms of the the demographics and those weren't kind of one-to-one matches but were closer and so you know there is there it's a it's a it's a very kind of challenging question because on the one hand there are are a myriad needs right and you think about from the kind of absenteeism to the wraparound supports you know on the other hand um you i think there was a real desire as we looked at all these inputs and all

[05:11:21] the kind of the various contexts which sort of defied any simple any kind of simple like oh here's the problem in terms of the theory of change that we did know and also consulted with sort of some of the work in other states including texas and sienna around that you know that getting to that high quality tier one instruction using these dollars as a catalyst for that right because it's i would also note that it's you know for some of these these schools where there's a lot as i looked at the spreadsheets of how many resources are going in like this is you know these are these are in some ways small small dollar amounts but that we would sort of say

[05:11:58] the priority was on the high quality instructional materials um you know and that's we as as ann described that's how we would provide the points um i would note that the broader work and i just want to be really clear here the broader work described by Dr. K. Wyatt around until we sort of get to that super app place of all of the dollars right the IDA the CLSD all of the title dollars which are the big kahuna like that that all of those dollars are sort of we know are kind

[05:12:31] of you know organized coherent addressing the broad set of needs in a in a more organized and kind of sort of highest and best use fashion that um you're not going to be able to address the full needs of these for the particular purposes of this grant its connection to spsf we wanted to prioritize the thing that was you know i would also note you know the focus here is also related to the higher expectations right and if you look at which schools and which students are most likely to be impacted by this raising the bar or below but you know

[05:13:10] know, for basic and for approaching and for proficient, it is these students. So kind of trying to make sure that there was alignment between where we were raising expectations and resources has been a priority since beginning to implement that plan.

[05:13:26] Thank you. And just one more kudos and a quick question. The TSI network idea, you know, we know from the literature network improvement communities, that kind of peer-to-peer sharing could be

really empowering uplifting so i'm just looking forward to hearing more uh who's responsive and how's that going and then last the question back to you know the tweaks that need to be made that those six csi schools that also get conditionally accredited seems like a doubly punitive aspect of the current system as well especially when you know the previous efforts

[05:14:03] separate accreditation from accountability was sort of an input outcomes kind of division. So is there an improvement in that area policy-wise that this board could be looking at? I think the challenge here is it's actually not just regulations. It's written into the state code. So it would likely involve a legislative change to truly say accreditation does not look at student outcomes. Yeah, I think it's written into the Code of Virginia as well as been reiterated our regulations so there may be less room that we can go here we try to i mean i think it is helpful

[05:14:40] that we have this discussion where the conditionally accredited pool is those that have not yet submitted satisfactory evidence so their schools were able to submit additional evidence to like the first our first pass was this may be a conditionally accredited school but once we got more evidence we were able to say no you're fully satisfactory fully accredited i think it is possible for us to get to 100 accredited even under this current system one of the challenges i will just say too that we especially when we go back and are looking at some of these schools and

[05:15:15] we're looking for multiple gears we haven't had a stable measurement system so if you're trying to look for like how do they do on spsf well we only had two years of data to look at and those two years were kind of different and are changing you know so i think as we as our measurement system stabilizes over time we will also be able to use our data more fully to see and look at different data points maybe not just pass rates to look at growth measures because we've had a stable growth measure for multiple years to look at chronic absenteeism to look at other data points within

[05:15:48] the spsf the old sort of accreditation system was very focused on this more narrow set of measures the spsf broadened that to some respect so i think there may be things that we can do within the current system once our measurement system is more stable we have more more measures at our disposal to look at on behalf of those csi schools um that do require this extra review but ultimately to take growth and progress out of accreditation will require by my understanding a legislative change gotcha oh well i just appreciate i know y'all are actively thinking about all these things i just wanted to lift that one up as a it's just a funky yeah funky little

[05:16:27] piece i know again when we're looking at thank you yeah um i just wanted to also comment on the the focus and the emphasis on the high quality instructional materials or hqims i think there is clear research that says particularly for the high unmet dr bridges um that what where where they see the most inconsistency is their lack of access to high quality instructional materials that are grade level aligned and that are rigorous and that that's where you see a lot of deviation

[05:17:05] and creativity and you know you know teachers pay teachers which i'm not against but the idea that you have to have you have to have consistent access to high quality instructional materials And so I think that I appreciate the focus on that being a high leverage tool and the flexibility to be able to also respond to the needs of the school community.

[05:17:31] community. So I definitely applaud that and want to also echo Dr. Bridge's point. This was a lot, you went through it a lot, but this is a huge amount of accomplishment of the team to bring this data together, to get the feedback from the field. And it is important for the public, which now there's 17 people

watching, but they'll go back, is that this is a major shift. We were at accreditation which did not talk about student performance and while i think accreditation is

[05:18:04] important it does give us some indicators into the quality and the experience of schools so i don't think we should take out accreditation and we now have a school performance framework that literally tells us how our schools and divisions are performing which gives us just great data and And this is, I think, the point you made earlier is like now we have the data to talk about accreditation, talk about performance, which then leads to support.

[05:18:36] And that is, I want to continue, I'm going to say whiplash, but the data is a little noisy right now. And it will continue to be noisy, but we're going to continue to work through it. And I, you know, I think what I'm reflecting on in superintendent, you and the team will have to continue to think through this.

[05:18:56] There's like a point where it's like, can we just rip the bandaid off and can we be there? And there is no there there because there is a process. That being said, how do you manage the urgency of the bar has to get high and continue to stay high and kids are going to high school and they only have four years to do it?

[05:19:16] And so it's like, how do we manage the urgency of keeping the bar high? And then we're going to get NAEP results out. Those come out every year, right? So we'll know how... Two years prior, it's always lagging. So it's lagging. We'll know about our progress.

[05:19:32] But in the meantime, how do we continue to listen to the field, keep the bar high, share the best practices, but then make the tough decisions when we need to in order to make Virginia lead the nation those are the points I'm going to end with which I think we can so again kudos to the team kudos again for this very detailed presentation and also to our teachers and divisions and principals the progress we see and we want to just continue to encourage and know

[05:20:08] there's good work that needs to be done but so much more work to be done with that anything else Okay. I think that officially is our agenda. We are now into concluding remarks and adjournment. Otherwise, can I have a motion to adjourn? All in favor? A second. All in favor? Just a whole roll thing, not a whole one thing.

[05:20:41] Anybody opposed? Anybody want to stay here any longer? Okay, great. All right. Motion. Meeting adjourned. Thank you.

